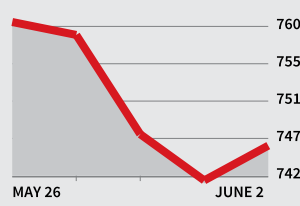


the hindu businessline

SENSEX 74649.84 (+382.50)



IN FOCUS

	LATEST	CHANGE
Nifty 50	23483.55	+100.95
P/E Ratio (Sensex)	20.20	+0.10
US Dollar (in ₹)	95.26	+0.27
Gold Std 10 gm (in ₹)	155668.00	+755
Silver 1 kg (in ₹)	265300.00	+2050



EL NINO THREAT

After record foodgrain production of 376.56 mt in FY26, government cuts FY27 target to 373.93 mt as El Nino looms **p10**

LOSING STEAM

LPG usage fell to its lowest in over 5 years in May with the Gulf conflict choking imports **p3**

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QUICKLY.

TARGETING ULTRA RICH
Godrej arm enters wealth management business



Mumbai: Godrej Industries, through its subsidiary Godrej Investments, has ventured into the wealth management business with the launch of Godrej Wealth, and targets building ₹1 lakh crore AUM in five years. It will cater to clients with minimum investable assets of ₹2 crore, including entrepreneurs, new-age wealth creators and sophisticated investors. **p2**

DEFYING GULF CRISIS
Air cargo volumes up 10% at 3.48 lakh tonnes in April

Chennai: The volume of air freight handled by Indian airports remained resilient in April despite the West Asia crisis. The air cargo handled by air route registered growth on month-on-month and year-on-year (y-o-y) basis in April. According to the AAI, total freight handled at Indian airports was up from 3.15 lakh tonnes in April 2025 to 3.48 lakh tonnes in April 2026. **p7**

April excise collection highest in 3 years despite levy cut on fuels

BURNING A HOLE. Expenditure on fertilizer subsidies surges with urea subsidy rising 56%

Shishir Sinha
New Delhi

Despite a ₹10/litre cut in levies on petrol and diesel, Central excise collections in April rose to ₹447 crore from a negative ₹39 crore in the corresponding month of the previous fiscal, data from the Controller General of Accounts (CGA) showed. The April collection is the highest in three years and the second highest in seven years.

At the same time, expenditure on fertilizer subsidy surged in April, with urea subsidy rising by over 56 per cent and nutrient-based fertilizer subsidy increasing 19 per cent.

FUELS' CONTRIBUTION
The bulk of the Central excise revenue comes from petrol, diesel, jet fuel and domestic crude oil, but global price fluctuations affect these products differently because of their tax structures. Petrol and diesel are taxed at a specific rate per litre, meaning global price volatility has no direct impact on the tax collected from these fuels. However,

Exercising excise

	Consumption (in '000 tonnes)			Collection (in ₹ cr)		Subsidy expenditure (in ₹ cr)	
	Petrol	Diesel	ATF	Central excise	Urea	NBS	
2023	2,877	7,818	656	960	5,798	9,362	
2024	3,285	7,925	742	70	4,781	811	
2025	3,449	8,261	772	(-)39	12,646	1,886	
2026	3,684	8,332	771	447	19,796	2,237	

Source: CGA

consumption volumes do influence revenue to some extent. In contrast, jet fuel, or aviation turbine fuel (ATF), is taxed on *ad valorem* basis, as a percentage of its market value.

According to data from the Petroleum Planning and Analysis Cell (PPAC), petrol consumption increased by over 6 per cent in April, while diesel use rose by around 1 per cent.

Sources said that given the modest growth in volumes, it appears that some refunds may have been deferred, benefiting Central excise collections.

It may be noted that on the day the duty cut was announced (March 27), officials estimated a net revenue loss of ₹5,500 crore in the first fortnight after accounting for windfall gains.

FERTILIZER SUBSIDY UP
At the same time, higher acquisition costs of imported urea and rising domestic production costs pushed urea subsidy outgo to around ₹20,000 crore, compared with over ₹12,600 crore a year ago.

The import price of urea rose to over \$950 a tonne from around \$530 a tonne in February, resulting in a higher subsidy burden. Subsidy expenditure on nutrient-based fertilizers also increased to over ₹2,200 crore from around ₹1,880 crore.

FISCAL DEFICIT HIT
According to Devendra Pant, Chief Economist at India Ratings and Research, the outgo on food and fertilizer subsidies increased 50.7 per cent, resulting in a 94.4 per cent year-on-year rise in the



fiscal deficit during the month.

However, he said that “one month’s data do not indicate the trend of public finances, which are likely to be under pressure due to the excise duty cut on petrol and diesel and likely higher petroleum and fertilizer subsidies”.

“We are concerned about the fiscal deficit outcome for April, particularly the expenditure run-rate,” said Aastha Gudwani, India Chief Economist at Barclays.

While there is likely an element of front-loading in the data as the government seeks to address the macroeconomic implications of the prolonged West Asia conflict, “this poses early risks to our base view that the fiscal deficit target for FY27 will be met”, she added.

Markets snap losing streak, led by IT stocks

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Benchmark indices reversed a four-session losing streak on Tuesday, with the Nifty IT Index leading a sharp intraday recovery that pulled markets out of early losses driven by geopolitical concerns and foreign institutional selling. Short-covering and value buying in select index-heavyweights helped market recovery.

“The rebound was primarily driven by buying in heavy-weight stocks across sectors despite persistent geopolitical uncertainty in West Asia and continued foreign institutional selling,” said Ajit Mishra, SVP Research at Religare Broking.

The BSE Sensex closed at 74,649.84, up 0.5 per cent, while the Nifty 50 settled at 23,483.55, up 0.43 per cent.

Despite today’s gains, South Korea pushed India to the seventh place in market-cap as FPIs continued to remain sellers. On Tuesday, they sold shares worth ₹8,363 crore, taking the total to ₹2.5 lakh crore in the current calendar year alone.

The rupee ended 0.3 per cent lower at 95.2650/dollar with the RBI’s intervention limiting losses.

See also **p6**

Producer Price Index to replace WPI over 5 years; services in bigger basket

Amiti Sen
New Delhi

In a major overhaul of inflation metrics, the Centre will launch a revised Wholesale Price Index (WPI) series this month, kickstarting a five-year transition to replace it entirely with a new Producer Price Index (PPI).

On June 15, the Department for Promotion of Industry and Internal Trade (DPIIT) will release the revised series of WPI with base year FY23, replacing the existing series with base year FY12, and incorporate an expanded basket of 957 commodities, up from 697 items, said Praveen Mahto, Principal Economic Advisor in the Commerce and Industry Ministry, on Tuesday.

Additions include items such as solar and wind energy and nuclear electricity.

NEW SERIES
Simultaneously, the government will introduce a new series of Output PPI, Trial Input PPI and Service PPI of seven services, covering banking, securities transaction, insurance, pension funds management, railways, air (passenger) and telecom.

“Considering the wide usage of the WPI in price escalation clauses, this index will be released for five years from the date of release of the revised series, along with PPI and will be discontinued thereafter. This will give users sufficient time to switch from WPI to PPI,” according to a DPIIT statement.

While the WPI tracks prices of goods at the wholesale/bulk level, PPI will track prices at the point of production (farm/factory-gate).

GLOBAL BEST PRACTICE
Pointing out the advantages of PPI over WPI, an official explained that PPI would be more consistent with the national account framework and align with global best practices adopted by advanced economies. “Availability of both Output PPI and Input PPI explains how inflation experienced by the producer on input items are passed through the output being produced. Further, both PPIs provide for an opportunity to eliminate the double counting of inflation unlike WPI. WPI covers goods only, whereas PPI includes services as well,” said the official.

Good energies will spread everywhere...

QUICKLY.

PepsiCo launches energy drink Adrenaline Rush

New Delhi: PepsiCo announced the launch of its premium energy drinks brand ‘Adrenaline Rush’ in the Indian market, strengthening its presence in the category. PepsiCo, a leading player in the energy drinks with its brand Sting, now enters the mass-premium segment, creating a portfolio that spans from ₹20 to ₹60 price-points. “PepsiCo is broadening consumer choice while addressing a wider range of taste preferences and consumption occasions,” the company said.

Shreeji Global FMCG Q4 profit rises 54 per cent

New Delhi: Shreeji Global FMCG, a Gujarat-based firm, has reported a 54.3 per cent rise in net profit to ₹8.81 crore for the quarter ended March 2026. The company had reported a net profit of ₹5.7 crore in the corresponding period a year ago. Revenue from operations increased 58 per cent to ₹472.91 crore (₹299 crore), according to a regulatory filing on Friday.

Coca-Cola looking at listing its leading bottler HCCH

STAKE SALE. It will explore sale of a portion of its shareholding through the process

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani
New Delhi

Beverage major Coca-Cola on Tuesday said that it is looking at a public listing of Hindustan Coca-Cola Holdings (HCCH) in 2027 on the bourses.

HCCH is the parent company of its largest bottler in India, Hindustan Coca-Cola Beverages (HCCB). It added that through the listing process, it will look at the sale of a portion of its shareholding in HCCH.

Coca-Cola owns 60 per cent stake in HCCH, while the rest 40 per cent is held by the Jubilant Bhartia Group.

The beverage major said this potential listing will complete the refranchising of HCCH while positioning it well to capitalise on the opportunities in the Indian market.

“Initial preparations are underway for a potential listing on the Bombay Stock Exchange and the National Stock Exchange of India,



INDIA OWNERSHIP. Coca-Cola owns 60 per cent stake in HCCH, while the rest is held by the Jubilant Bhartia Group

subject to market conditions and applicable regulatory and other approvals,” the company said. It has retained Rothschild & Co to advise on the listing.

In July 2025, the Jubilant Bhartia Group completed the acquisition of a 40 per cent stake in HCCH.

PURSUE GROWTH
Sanket Ray, President-India and South-West Asia and Emerging Large Markets Lead for the Coca-Cola

Company, said, “This announcement is another important step for HCCB. Following the listing, the bottler will be well placed to continue to pursue growth. The Coca-Cola Company will stay invested in this important bottler and focus on growing our portfolio of global and local brands in India.”

“We are excited to take this next important step in the bottler’s journey and reap the benefits of the pub-

lic listing to create value for all shareholders. Equally, we are looking forward to continuing to work with The Coca-Cola Company, as an important shareholder in the company,” added Shyam and Hari Bhartia, Chairman and Co-Chairman, Jubilant Bhartia Group.

Established in 1997, HCCH and its operating subsidiary HCCB operate a network of more than 2,000 distributors and reach over 1.7 million customers.

HCCB operates 14 bottling plants across 10 States and works with eight co-packers. It employs 5,000 people currently.

In the past, the beverage major had refranchised several territories which were under HCCB to existing independent bottlers.

HCCB prepares, packages, distributes and sells both sparkling and still beverages of the company’s portfolio, including Coca-Cola, Thums Up, Sprite, Fanta, Limca, Maaza and Minute Maid, among others.

That’s the reason we invest in building in India. We’re seeing significant growth, so we’re excited about what we’re building and doing with customers. In some cases, we’re leading across Asia and setting the template for enterprise-scale AI adoption not just in the global South, but the world.

Many workers worry that AI could lead to job losses as companies seek greater efficiency. Is that concern justified? Is Microsoft expanding its workforce in India?

AI is reducing repetitive work, not eliminating roles. Rule-based tasks are getting automated, allowing us to lift human potential to do more higher-value-added thinking and decision-making work. The nature of work is shifting across functions.

Skills are becoming more important than job titles, and careers will become more fluid. We will move across roles more quickly based on the skills we bring to the table. We are also excited about new roles like AI workflow designers, agent managers, AI trainers and evaluators.

The key for us is adaptability. Anybody willing to learn fast and apply AI to work will come out on the right side of this equation. We continue to hire in areas where we’re seeing customer demand and where we’re building new capabilities across the board.

How AT1 bond issuances have hit a rough patch since 2025

Lokeshwarri SK
Chennai

Additional Tier 1 bonds or AT1 bonds have been caught in one scandal after another, making issuers shy away from them in recent years. Only ₹3,500 crore was raised through these bonds in 2025, registering a 79 per cent decline from the issuances worth ₹16,859 crore in 2024.

DATA FOCUS.

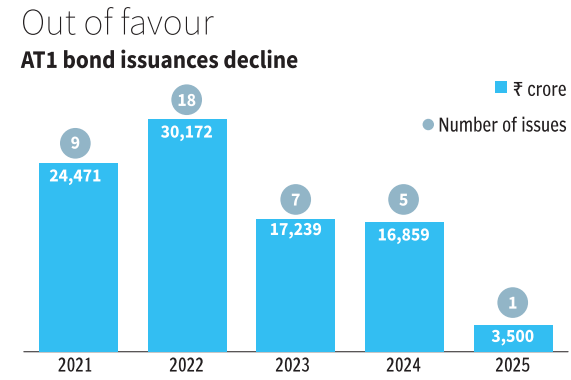
AT1 bonds are high-yielding but very risky instruments issued by banks to meet capital requirements under Basel-III norms. These are perpetual bonds, which means that they have no maturity date and can be written off or converted into equity by the RBI if faced with a financial crisis. This means that not only will the investor have to forego interest, but the principal can also be lost under some circumstances.

These bonds have been involved in several cases of mis-selling where the high returns were highlighted but not the risk. Employees of HDFC Bank’s Dubai branch were found mis-selling AT1 bonds of Credit Suisse to their NRI clients. The Supreme Court is yet to give its final order on Yes Bank’s write-off of AT1 bonds worth ₹8,415 crore in 2020.

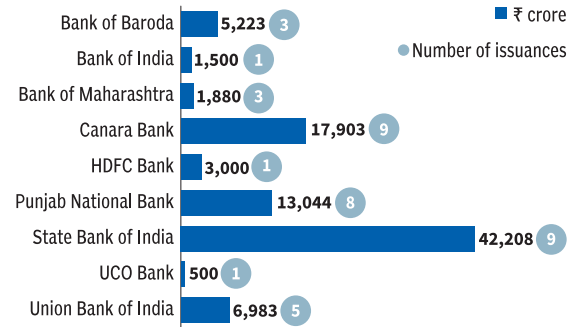
DECLINING NUMBERS

Data compiled by Prime Database for the period from 2021 show these bonds continued to be in favour until 2024. In 2021, nine AT1 bond issuances were recorded, raising ₹24,271 crore. In 2022, 18 issues raised ₹30,172 crore. But the numbers almost halved in 2023 and 2024, before completely dwindling in 2025.

“The decline in AT1 bond issuances is the result of a combination of factors: the



SBI and Canara Bank made the most issues since 2021



Source: primedatabase.com

hybrid debt-equity nature of the instrument, regulatory and valuation debates, the aftermath of the Yes Bank and Credit Suisse events, concerns over pricing adequacy, a limited investor base and increasingly selective investor appetite,” says Venkatakrishnan Srinivasan, founder and managing partner of debt advisory firm Rockfort Fincap.

The strong balance sheets of banks following the pandemic, when they were able to reduce stressed assets, could have led to lower requirement for capital in the last few years.

If we consider bank-wise issuances since 2021, PSU banks are at the forefront in raising funds through AT1 bonds. SBI has raised the most funds at ₹42,208 crore from nine issuances. Canara Bank, which has raised ₹17,903 crore, and Punjab National Bank, which raised

₹13,044 crore, are some of the other PSBs which have used this channel for raising money.

Among private sector banks, only HDFC Bank has issued AT1 bonds worth ₹3,000 crore in 2022.

Interestingly, banks have switched to issuing AT2 bonds since 2024. These bonds are one notch less risky than AT1 bonds and can be redeemed after five years.

“The future growth of the market will depend on whether issuers and investors can arrive at a more balanced risk-reward framework that appropriately reflects the unique characteristics of these instruments. If issuers are willing to offer spreads commensurate with the embedded risks, investor demand can continue to exist, particularly for top-rated public sector banks and AAA-rated private sector banks,” adds Srinivasan.

Anthropic files confidentially for IPO in race with OpenAI for a debut this fall

Bloomberg

Anthropic PBC has confidentially submitted draft paperwork for a public listing, potentially leapfrogging longtime rival OpenAI in the race toward a Wall Street debut as soon as this fall.

“The number of shares to be offered and the price have not yet been set,” said the company in a blog post. Anthropic, once viewed as an underdog to OpenAI, has vaulted ahead of the Chat-GPT maker in recent months on multiple fronts.

The Claude developer raised \$65 billion in a funding round last week at a \$965-billion valuation, in-

cluding the investment, eclipsing OpenAI’s value for the first time. Anthropic’s advances in coding and cybersecurity capabilities have rattled markets and also enticed new business customers. It has made headlines recently for experiencing an 80-fold increase in annualised revenue.

FILING ON MONDAY

With the filing on Monday, Anthropic is poised to potentially beat OpenAI to the public market, setting itself up to attract more attention and capital from a greater pool of investors.

OpenAI itself was said to be preparing its own confidential filing for an initial pub-

lic offering in the coming weeks and was targeting a public debut sometime in the fall.

In an interview, OpenAI Chief Executive Officer Sam Altman played down the idea that his firm is in a race with Anthropic to go public. “We’ll do it when we think it’ll make sense,” he said.

Anthropic and rival OpenAI have spent much of the past year one-upping each other with a flurry of AI model releases aimed at streamlining a wider range of professional tasks — from coding to financial services to healthcare — with the goal of courting more business customers and justifying their lofty valuations.

Godrej Industries group ventures into wealth management, targets ₹1 lakh crore assets in 5 years

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Godrej Industries, through its subsidiary Godrej Investments, has ventured into the wealth management business with the launch of Godrej Wealth and targets ₹1 lakh crore assets under management (AUM) in the next five years.

The business will primarily cater to clients with investable assets of ₹2 crore and above, including entrepreneurs, new-age wealth creators and sophisticated investors with multi-asset needs.

Godrej Group plans to launch the IPO of Godrej Capital in five years and invest ₹5,000-7,000 crore in

the pre-IPO stage. It will invest ₹500 crore in the wealth management business and plans to enter mutual funds in the near future.

Godrej Capital has two entities — the non-bank finance company Godrej Finance and the housing finance company Godrej Housing Finance — in operation for five years and has an AUM of ₹30,000 crore.

WEALTH NETWORK

To start with, the wealth arm will open eight offices this year and grow it to 35 over the next two-three years.

Pirojsha Godrej, Chairperson Designate, Godrej Industries Group, said that he envisages wealth management and financial services to be the fastest-growing business within the group.

The Group has set a target to increase sales by at least 15 per cent a year over the next five years, grow EPS by at least 20 per cent a year and achieve return on equity of 18 per cent at each business level. These three things will imply a Group value of about ₹5 lakh crore by 2031, he said.



Pirojsha Godrej, Chairperson Designate, Godrej Industries Group

The financial services component with both the lending and wealth management business can have an AUM of ₹1 lakh crore each in five years, he added.

The lending business, which includes NBFC and housing finance, have already grown steadily and financial services will be at least 10 per cent of the overall value creation of the Group by 2031, he said.

On one side of the wealth management industry, he said there are banks, which are not ideal wealth managers because they have incentives to keep higher amounts in deposits, creat-

To start with, the wealth arm will open eight offices this year and grow it to 35 over the next two-three years

ing an inherent conflict of interest.

“The rest of the market is heavily focused on the ultra-high-net-worth category, which is not the segment Godrej Wealth will be targeting,” he said.

GROUP SYNERGY

Manish Shah, MD and CEO, Godrej Capital, said Godrej Wealth was a compelling proposition as it gives an opportunity to build a start-up within a 129-year-old organisation.

On the possible synergies within the group, Godrej said last year, Godrej Properties sold over one lakh homes, so a lot of these customers who trusted the Godrej Group might be interesting clients and opportunities on the wealth side.

Olectra targets EV bus fleet expansion, bets on 55-tonne EV trucks with ₹600 crore capex plan

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

After clocking ₹2,312 crore in FY26 revenue, Olectra Greentech is internally targeting turnover of around ₹4,000-4,500 crore by FY27, as the company prepares a major expansion into heavy electric trucks, battery systems and integrated EV manufacturing.

Speaking to *businessline*, Mahesh Babu, Managing Director of Olectra Greentech, said the company’s next growth phase would be driven by heavy commercial EVs, integrated manufacturing and energy businesses as electrification expands beyond buses into freight and industrial transportation.

“Olectra’s performance reflects our continued focus on sustained and profitable growth across both our mobility and energy businesses,” Babu said.

The Hyderabad-based company is expected to invest ₹400-500 crore over the next two years across new platforms and production infrastructure, while longer-term investments could

We are deliberately starting from the top end because heavy-duty applications already make economic sense for electrification

MAHESH BABU
MD, Olectra Greentech



range between ₹2,000 crore and ₹5,000 crore spanning products, capacity expansion and battery systems.

India’s largest electric bus maker delivered 1,280 EVs in FY26 and ended the year with an order-book of 10,161 vehicles. Its deployed EV fleet now stands at nearly 4,000 vehicles nationwide.

HEAVY TRUCK PUSH

At the centre of Olectra’s next growth phase is its planned entry into heavy electric trucks — a segment still at a nascent stage in India. The company is developing a 55-tonne electric tractor trailer and a 38-tonne electric tipper, with commercial deliveries expected

from the last quarter of FY27.

Unlike several EV startups focusing on light commercial cargo vehicles, Olectra is betting on heavy-duty applications where vehicles running 300-400 km daily already offer stronger total-cost-of-ownership economics over diesel fleets. “We are deliberately starting from the top end because heavy-duty applications already make economic sense for electrification,” Babu said, pointing to demand from mining, construction, ports and industrial transportation operators.

The company believes financing, rather than technology, could become the

biggest barrier for electric truck adoption in India.

Babu said extending EV financing tenures from the current three-four years to six-seven years could significantly improve adoption by aligning EMIs more closely with operating savings. India’s electric truck market remains tiny at an estimated 600-800 units in FY26, but Olectra internally expects annual demand could cross 3,000 units by FY28-29.

FUTURE PLANS

Olectra is evaluating a blade battery pack assembly line in India with technology support linked to BYD, while also expanding sourcing partnerships with Indian battery suppliers to reduce dependence on a single ecosystem.

The company has consolidated operations at its 150-acre Seetharampur Industrial Park near Hyderabad, which it describes as among India’s largest integrated electric bus manufacturing hubs. It is developing next-generation 7 m, 9 m and 12 m bus platforms, alongside up-graded intercity electric coaches.

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Index of improvement

Revised IIP will work as a better policy guide

The new index of industrial production (IIP), unveiled on Monday with the release of the April figures, marks a watershed in data reforms. The factory output data for April, captured now by a more granular and contemporary data base, suggests that the impact of the war has been less than catastrophic. An industry growth rate of 4.9 per cent is led by manufacturing (6.2 per cent), but pulled down by mining (minus 5.1 per cent). Manufacturing sector growth has been led by motor vehicles, electricals, computers and machinery.



Signs of a recovery in manufacture of chemicals, a sector whose fortunes are tied up with the Iran war, are encouraging. However, April data is not strictly comparable with earlier periods, in view of the altered composition of the index. For now, it tells us that industrial output linked to supplies from China or elsewhere has been less impacted. The new index has been constructed with 2022-23 as base year. IIP was last revised way back in 2014, with 2011-12 as the base year; since then, there have been notable structural changes in Indian industry. In order to reflect the current and evolving reality, the new index has included 120 new item groups and weeded out 63. As a chain index (earlier, a fixed base index), it is meant to accommodate swift changes in a fluid world order, such as the emergence of new sectors or the diminution of existing ones. Overall, 1,042 products have been mapped to 463 item groups, against 837 items to 407 item groups in the 2011-12 index. A new category — water supply, sewerage and waste management with a weight of 2 per cent — has been included. Minerals includes rare earths as well. The addition of 50 product groups in manufacturing, from 405 to 455, marks a significant updation effort. Electricity has been split into renewables and non-renewables to measure the output of each, providing information on emission-related reforms.

However, the new index can be fine-tuned; the report of the committee concerned makes some useful suggestions. First, the IIP series should be ‘deseasonalised’, with a unit being set up for this task at the Ministry of Statistics. Second, the Annual Survey of Unorganised Sector Enterprises, which began about five years ago, can work towards creating industry-level indicators which can be synced with IIP to capture total industrial output. This could take time, but is very important. Third, GST data can be used to develop business registries over the next two years. It can plug data gaps, given that the new IIP seeks to capture changes in output composition quickly, and might be hampered by lags in Annual Survey of Industries data. The use of accurate deflators to match the new IIP categories is a crucial requirement, for which a producer price index is necessary. These gaps should be addressed, so that the new IIP can reliably guide policymakers.

POCKET

RAVIKANTH



Remittances: A buffer, now under pressure

WORRYING SIGNS. For years remittances have bridged the trade gap. With the tightening labour markets and AI threat in the West, these flows may be impacted



India is structurally a current account deficit (CAD) economy. The main driver of the deficit is the merchandise trade gap. That gap widened from roughly \$6 billion in 2000-01 to \$284 billion in 2024-25. Net services exports and remittances increasingly offset it. While the role of software exports is well known, in the clamour for capital inflows, remittances are often overlooked. Remittances reached \$135 billion in 2024-25, which covered about 47.5 per cent of India's trade deficit. In 2024-25, remittances comfortably exceeded gross FDI inflows. In fact, in most years from 2000-01 to 2024-25, remittances have remained higher than FDI inflows. It is worth noting that since 2008, India has become the world's largest recipient of remittances. Over these years, India's remittance flows have remained stable. They were little affected by global shocks, thereby serving as a buffer during episodes of capital-flow volatility. Remittances are generally safe and stable, carry no reversal risk, and accrue directly to household balance sheets, thereby dampening rather than amplifying external-sector stress. But now it faces a magnitude of technological, economic, and geopolitical headwinds. The consequences could reach the balance of payments and the rupee.

REMITTANCE PROFILE India's remittance composition has shifted decisively. The latest RBI survey on remittances, published in 2025, tracks changes between 2016-17 and 2023-24. The US has overtaken the UAE as the largest source of remittances to India. The US share rose from 22.9 to

27.7 per cent. The UAE's share fell from 26.9 to 19.2 per cent. Advanced economies now supply over half of inflows. This bloc includes the US, UK, Singapore, Canada, and Australia. The Gulf countries' combined share has slipped to 38 per cent. The shift reflects a structural change in India's migrant base. Skilled professionals in OECD economies are dominating over semi-skilled Gulf labour in terms of remittance flows. This rising concentration is not without cost. Inflows are now drawn from a small set of advanced economies, particularly the US. That raises India's vulnerability to host-country policies and labour-market conditions. In recent times, several US policy changes have the potential to affect remittance flows to India. The first is the One Big Beautiful Bill Act, signed into law on July 4, 2025. It introduces a 1 per cent levy. The levy applies only to cash, money order, or cashier's cheque transfers. It exempts other channels, such as electronic transfers from US bank accounts or US-issued debit and credit cards. The Bill is not yet materially damaging. But it may foreshadow similar levies in the future.

VISA PRESSURE The second policy is possibly more damaging. It operates through the migration channel. A \$100,000 fee for certain new H-1B visas took effect on September 21, 2025. It sits on top of the

AI and workflow automation have hit high-wage, code-and-document occupations (software engineering, customer service) that have been the mainstay of Indian white-collar workers

previous fee envelope. That envelope typically ran several thousand dollars per petition. The third channel is the reported tightening of US student visas. Its effect on remittances may be felt over the long term. The other major shock is technological change and its impact on the labour market in advanced economies, particularly the US. Data show that through mid-May 2026, roughly 1,13,000 tech-sector jobs were eliminated globally across approximately 179 companies in the first five months of the year, with over three-quarters of those losses concentrated in the US. Another study found that 47.9 per cent of the cuts were explicitly attributed by employers to AI or workflow automation. The displacement is concentrated in precisely the high-wage, code-and-document occupations — software engineering, customer service, marketing, and sales — that have been the mainstay of Indian white-collar workers over the past decade.

AI FACTOR The political system has begun to acknowledge the shift. On May 21, Governor Gavin Newsom of California signed Executive Order N-6-26, the first such action by any US Governor to address AI-driven workforce disruption. The order directs state agencies to deliver, within 90 and 180 days, recommendations on a range of responses: revisions to the California WARN Act so that mass-layoff notification functions as an early-warning signal for AI displacement, expanded unemployment insurance and retraining programs for affected white-collar workers, worker-ownership models, and — most novel — a concept Newsom termed “universal basic capital”. It would give every resident a small ownership stake in productive assets, such as corporate equities, bonds, or units of a public wealth fund, so that

workers displaced by AI can share in those profits as owners. This method tries to avoid criticisms associated with direct beneficiary transfers, such as a universal basic income. Several takeaways follow. First, California is now seriously considering a system that gives people ownership of capital rather than wages from work. That is a strong indication of a structural shift in the labour market. Demand for the jobs typically performed by Indian white-collar workers is likely to decline secularly. Second, as framed, these benefits will not extend to H-1B visa holders from India. The order is still exploratory, not law. But it may signal that the white-collar wage-income story, central to India's remittance success, is changing in a definitive way. Third, AI-driven displacement will eventually spread to other developed countries. Together they account for more than half of India's remittances. Remittances from the GCC face a different set of risks. They are exposed to two interacting geopolitical pressures. First, a renewed Israel-Iran or Red Sea escalation could disrupt Gulf oil revenues, tourism and other business receipts. Second, a sustained softening of crude prices could force GCC governments to accelerate labour-nationalisation programmes. These include Saudi Arabia's Nitaqat, also known as Saudization, and the UAE's Emiratization. Such measures could displace large numbers of Indian blue-collar workers in the Gulf. In the days to come, such multifaceted disruptions could shake the foundation of India's most stable source of foreign exchange earnings. Hence, these developments do not gel well in India's external finance front. These have important implications for future exchange-rate movements.

Pal is a Professor at IIM Calcutta, Kolkata; Ray is Director, NIBM, Pune. Views expressed are personal

What will the MPC do this time?

In a business as usual scenario, the MPC will keep the status quo — unless it chooses to challenge ‘rational expectations’

Madan Sabnavis Robert Lucas and Thomas Sargent were proponents of the famous Rational Expectations theory. The theory said that if monetary or any policy is predictable, it ceases to have any impact on economic variables. If everybody knows that the central bank will act only when inflation crosses the defined threshold, it will be business as usual. However, if the central bank suddenly announces a major change, then the impact will be significant.

In a business as usual scenario, there is little reason for one to expect any action from the Monetary Policy Committee. Inflation is well below the 4 per cent mark. It can be argued that inflation will cross the 5 per cent mark based on the global conditions as well as the policy actions taken by the government and OMCs. The question then is whether the MPC will wait for this number to materialise or act in anticipation by increasing the repo rate. But 5 per cent is within the range of 4-6 per cent; therefore, there is no need to take any pre-emptive action now.

Therefore, the RBI projection of inflation is critical. Further, if the MPC acts this time, and the war ends leading to rollback of some measures, the present move will look hasty. If inflation rate does actually cross 6 per cent, can it be considered to be transitory or permanent? The general consensus hence is that there will be a status quo in repo rate, as inflation is low. The stance too may not change as changing to withdrawal of accommodation will be ambivalent — as liquidity is being provided by the RBI. A new term, such as ‘possible tightening’ or ‘calibrated tightening’ based on circumstances can be used, which is forward-looking. Such articulation can be more potent than action.

RATIONAL EXPECTATIONS But if the MPC wants to play a different game, going by the ‘rational expectations’ theory, it can go for a rate hike well before it is needed. Say, a 25 bps or even 50 bps hike will send a strong message that inflation will not be tolerated. This will spike bond yields, raising expectations of more rate hikes. Given exchange rate worries, an



RBI. Crucial policy call REUTERS

increase in rates will be positive for FPI investors in the debt segment. This can be a collateral benefit of increasing the repo rate though not a rationale. On the other side, raising rates now will mean higher cost of borrowing for the government. As the RBI is also the banker to the government, the latter has to keep this factor in mind. Higher rates will come in the way of future growth as investment becomes cautious, which in turn will lower aggregate demand in the system. Also as monetary policy should be forward looking, acting before the event carries more weight. The present economic environment

which has been conditioned to a large extent by the global developments has made monetary policy formulation more difficult. Crude oil is one single factor which has upset calculations everywhere with inflation being the single most important threat. There is speculation also on whether the Federal Reserve under the new Chairman would be forced to raise rates. The situation back home is one typified by rising inflation and volatile currency at a time when the fiscal deficit could also go beyond the targeted number leading to higher government borrowing. In such a situation it would be tempting to raise the repo rate assuming that the higher inflation will materialise as the war drags on (with the El Nino effect adding to the inflation number in the second half of the year). The risk however is on the growth front as premature raising of rates could slowdown investment while not really affecting cost-push inflation. The upcoming credit policy becomes interesting, with these variables at work.

The writer is Chief Economist, Bank of Baroda. Views expressed are personal

✉ **LETTERS TO EDITOR** Send your letters by email to bleditor@thehindu.co.in or by post to ‘Letters to the Editor’, The Hindu Business Line, Kasturi Buildings, 859-860, Anna Salai, Chennai 600002.

Tariff tangle The possibility of India revisiting tariff concessions on Scotch whisky in response to the UK's steel curbs raises a question that extends beyond the arithmetic of tariffs and quotas. At stake is the principle of reciprocity, the foundation for trade ties. The India-UK FTA was envisioned as a landmark economic compact, with bilateral trade projected to expand by nearly \$25.5 billion by 2040. India's decision to progressively reduce tariffs on Scotch whisky represented a significant gesture of market openness. Yet Britain's move to tighten steel safeguard measures and curtail tariff-free access for imports risks unsettling the carefully

negotiated balance that underpins the agreement. India's measured response should therefore be viewed not as retaliation but as an effort to preserve the integrity of the agreement itself. **Vijay Singh Adhikari** Nainital, Uttarakhand **Fragmented Railways** The article ‘Railways splintered into too many zones’, (June 2) is an insightful analysis that exposes how political vanity consistently derails structural logic. Splitting a massive rail network into tiny regional territories is a cosmetic fix that only creates more red tape. Creating these extra headquarters

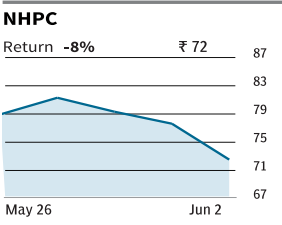
does nothing to add new tracks, improve punctuality, or increase safety. Instead, it simply multiplies senior job posts to please local politicians. In today's digital age, adding bureaucratic layers makes no sense. True reform means stopping this expansion, merging overlapping zones, and giving real power and resources directly to the local working divisions. **Babu Crishna** Bengaluru **Political compulsions** I write in reference to Sudhanshu Mani's article, ‘Railways splintered into too many zones’. The author rightly argues that the creation of

additional railway zones is often driven by political considerations rather than operational efficiency. The operationalisation of the South Coast Railway as the 18th zone raises important questions about whether increasing administrative layers actually improves railway performance. While new zones may satisfy regional aspirations, they do not automatically enhance safety, punctuality, freight movement, or network capacity. These objectives are primarily achieved at the divisional level, where day-to-day operations are managed. At a time when Indian Railways is investing heavily in modernisation through initiatives such as Dedicated Freight Corridors, Kavach safety

Vidyasagar Reddy Kethiri Warangal

QUICKLY.

NHPC offer-for-sale subscribed 3.5x on Day 1



New Delhi: The government on Tuesday decided to exercise the green shoe option in the 6 per cent stake sale in the state-owned NHPC through Offer for Sale (OFS), following an overwhelming response from investors on the first day of subscription. The OFS received an encouraging response from investors and was oversubscribed 3.47 times on the first day. Allocation will be on a price priority basis. The government has decided to exercise the entire green shoe option. Retail investors and employees get to bid on 3rd June 2026,” Department of Investment and Public Asset Management Secretary Arunish Chawla said in a post on X. **PTI**

Govt invites forms for 2 SEBI whole-time members

Mumbai: The government has invited applications till June 40 for the appointment of two whole-time members (WTMs) of Securities and Exchange Board of India (SEBI). The government has indicated a preference for candidates with more than 20 years of professional experience and within the age group of 45 to 60 years. The tenure of a whole-time member will be up to five years, subject to the condition that the appointee shall not continue beyond the age of 65 years. Reappointment will be permissible under the applicable rules. **OUR BUREAU**

Pick-up in IT stocks arrests market slide

LOSING MOJO. But Indian stocks slip to 7th spot behind South Korea in market cap as FPIs continue their selling

Anupama Ghosh
Mumbai

Benchmark indices reversed a four-session losing streak on Tuesday, with the Nifty IT index leading a sharp intraday recovery that pulled markets out of early losses driven by geopolitical concerns and foreign institutional selling. Besides, short-covering and value buying in select index heavyweights also helped market recovery. “The rebound was primarily driven by buying in heavy-weight stocks across sectors despite persistent geopolitical uncertainty in the West Asia and continued foreign institutional selling,” said Ajit Mishra, SVP Research at Religare Broking. The BSE Sensex closed at 74,649.84, up 382.50 points and Nifty ended at 23,483.55, gaining 100.95 points. The Nifty Midcap 100 rose 0.19 per cent and the Smallcap

100 gained 0.40 per cent. However, despite today's gains, South Korea pushed India to seventh place in market-cap. Within a few days, semiconductor-heavy Taiwan (\$5.15 trillion) and now South Korea (\$5 trillion) overtook India (\$4.85 trillion), as FPIs remained massive sellers of domestic stocks. On Tuesday, FPIs sold shares worth ₹8,363 crore, taking the total selling to nearly ₹2.5 lakh crore in 2026 alone.

TCS, INFY LEAD SURGE Wednesday's standout performer was the Nifty IT index, which surged 4.3 per cent, with TCS gaining 6.5 per cent and Infosys 5.7 per cent. The rally was driven by positive commentary from global technology companies on AI-led demand, improving revenue visibility for Indian IT exporters, and a



RISING STARS. The Nifty IT index surged 4.3 per cent with Infosys and TCS gaining around 6 per cent each **REUTERS**

weakening rupee that benefits dollar-earning companies. IT stocks have now gained over 7 per cent in the last three sessions. Short covering ahead of the weekly Nifty expiry also contributed to the bounce back. India VIX declined about 7 per cent to 16.03, signalling improved risk-on sentiment. On the sectoral front,

Consumer Durables, FMCG, Auto, PSU Banks, Metals, and Realty ended in positive territory. Healthcare, Pharma, and Oil & Gas were the session's notable laggards, with the Pharma index shedding nearly 1 per cent on profit booking. **MACRO BOOSTER** On the macro front, the IIP grew 4.9 per cent on year in

April, with capital goods growth reinforcing the view that the domestic capex cycle remains healthy. India-US trade negotiations are underway in New Delhi from June 2-4, with reports suggesting most key elements have been finalised. Rahul Singh, CIO-Equities, Tata Asset Management, said geopolitical tensions continue to keep crude oil prices elevated, while mixed global signals have resulted in bond yields remaining high and the rupee staying under pressure. This has increased the risk premium on Indian equities and weighed on market valuations. “Despite these challenges, the impact on corporate earnings has been manageable so far, and management commentary during the fourth-quarter earnings season has remained encouraging,” he said.

PPFAS defers GIFT City launch of India-focused funds

Avinash Nair
Ahmedabad

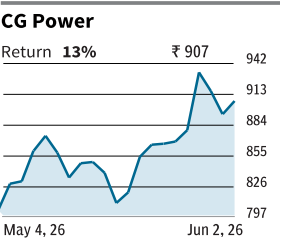
Parag Parikh Financial Advisory Services Ltd (PPFAS) has put on hold the launch of two India-focused investment schemes from GIFT City amid ongoing tensions in West Asia, even as its recently launched outbound funds investing in US markets benefited from the market recovery that followed the conflict. PPFAS had planned simultaneous launch of inbound and outbound products through its GIFT City arm, PPFAS Alternate Asset Managers IFSC Pvt Ltd. “We are planning to bring in two inbound schemes because there are many investors who are looking to invest in India. We have already received approval for our inbound schemes. But due to the war situation these products got stalled, otherwise our earlier plan was to launch both inbound

and outbound schemes together,” Hema Thakkar, Head-Business Development, PPFAS Alternate Asset Managers IFSC, said. In March, it launched Parag Parikh IFSC S&P 500 FoF and Parag Parikh IFSC Nasdaq 100 FoF, which provide exposure to US equities. The schemes are targeted at retail investors seeking global diversification, family offices and HNIs, with a minimum investment of \$5,000. “We were lucky to have got the timing right,” Nirmal Bari, Principal Officer and Director, PPFAS, said, adding that the underlying indices have gained more than 20 per cent since then. For PPFAS, however, the bigger opportunity may lie in inbound funds that channel overseas capital into India. The launch of these funds will now depend on how quickly geopolitical conditions stabilise and international marketing efforts can resume, officials added.

Nomura bullish on India data centre industry

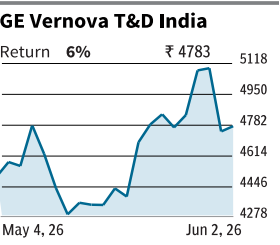
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Global brokerage Nomura believes India's data centre industry is entering a multi-year growth phase driven by accelerating digitalisation, cloud adoption and rising artificial intelligence-linked demand, with CG Power and GE Vernova T&D India emerging as its preferred plays. Nomura said India's data centre industry is likely to record over 30 per cent CAGR during CY25-30, outperforming the broader APAC market as the country emerges as one of the fastest-growing hubs globally. India's data centre IT load capacity increased from



around 350 MW in 2019 to nearly 1.5-1.6 GW in 2025, implying around 29 per cent CAGR compared with about 20 per cent globally. It added that India's share in global data centre capacity has increased from around 1.5 per cent in 2019 to nearly 2-3 per cent in 2025.

CAPEX DRIVERS Nomura identified five key product categories that to-



gether account for nearly 60-75 per cent of data centre capex budgets, including switchgear and transformers, UPS and battery systems, backup diesel and gas generators, cooling systems, and structured cabling infrastructure. **TOP PICKS** The brokerage highlighted ABB India, Siemens, Hitachi Energy India, GE Vernova

T&D India, CG Power and Cummins India as major participants in the ecosystem. Among these, Nomura has assigned 'Buy' ratings only to GE Vernova T&D India and CG Power, while ABB India carries a 'Reduce' rating, Siemens and Cummins India are rated 'Neutral', and Hitachi Energy India is not rated. Nomura added that delivery lead times of two to four years have created a favourable seller's market with multi-year order backlogs for companies operating in the data centre supply chain. It also expects premium pricing trends to sustain as data centre projects require higher reliability, tighter customisation, faster execution timelines and on-site engineering support.

smallcase unveils MF model portfolios

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Investment platform smallcase has expanded beyond stocks and ETFs with the launch of mutual fund model portfolios, aiming to help investors move from selecting individual schemes to investing through professionally managed portfolio strategies. smallcase has introduced more than 30 MF portfolios across categories such as fund picks, multi-asset strategies and cash management solutions. The portfolios combine direct funds across AMCs and are designed around specific investment objectives, risk profiles and time horizons.

“Over the years, we've seen investors move from selecting individual products to seeking more structured portfolio approaches... MF smallcases help investors move from choosing individual funds to managed investment strategies,” said Vasanth Kamath, Founder and CEO, smallcase. **NEW FORAY** The launch marks the company's entry into a new segment after building its business around model portfolios of stocks, ETFs, REITs and InvITs. He said the MF model portfolio format addresses a growing challenge for retail investors: navigating an increasingly crowded MF universe and constructing balanced port-

folios aligned to their goals. “The whole concept of investing with an objective becomes way more simpler with mutual fund smallcases. Whether it is parking cash, building a multi-asset portfolio, selecting fund managers across categories or investing towards a long-term goal, the portfolio format helps simplify decision-making for investors,” he said. Drawing parallels with global markets, Kamath said model portfolios have become a major channel for wealth management in developed markets and expects a similar trend to emerge in India. “We believe model portfolios will become an important layer between investors and investment products,” he added.

IPO issuers decide to wait rather than resize offerings

Akshata Gorde
Mumbai

Companies planning public offerings are largely choosing to wait for better market conditions rather than resize offerings, as valuation expectations continue to weigh on launch decisions amid volatile markets. In April, markets regulator SEBI allowed companies to reduce IPO sizes by up to 50 per cent without refiling offer documents to help companies navigate a period of heightened market volatility and uncertain investor sentiment. However, advisers said issue size remains one of the last variables companies are willing to revisit. **VALUATION IS KEY** “Currently, we do not anticipate issuers to substantially alter their IPO size,” said Sourav Modi, Partner, JSA Advocates & Solicitors.

“The macroeconomic conditions coupled with the valuation expectations of the issuers and investors not aligning in current market conditions makes it more challenging to approach the market through IPOs.” Sahil Bora, Partner at JSR Capital Advisors, said that a significant number of promoter groups, private equity investors and pre-IPO shareholders continue to anchor their expectations to the strong market conditions seen between 2021 and early 2025, when liquidity was abundant, public market multiples were elevated and IPO markets remained supportive. However, the current market environment has changed meaningfully. “For certain PE and pre-IPO investors, accepting lower valuation multiples can materially impact expected returns, particularly where entry valuations were established during a more eu-

phoric market phase,” Bora said. As a result, many issuers are choosing to reassess launch plans rather than compromise on valuations unless market conditions leave them with limited alternatives. “Most companies would still prefer to wait for better market conditions rather than reduce issue size too early, because a visible cut can be interpreted as weak demand,” said Soumya Singh, Co-founding Partner, Thistle & Law. A reduction in issue size can affect offer-for-sale proceeds, secondary sales, alter transaction economics and create a lower public-market benchmark for future exits, Singh said. Companies are rather accessing anchor investor demand, institutional feedback, valuation support, offer-for-sale quantum, pricing considerations and launch timing before revisiting issue size.

BROKER'S CALL.

Motilal Oswal Research

KNR CONSTRUCTIONS (NEUTRAL) Target: ₹130 CMP: ₹132.10 KNR Constructions' revenue declined about 37 per cent to about ₹530 crore during Q4FY26 (16 per cent above our estimate). EBITDA margin decreased 850 bp to 5.3 per cent (vs. our estimate of 9.9 per cent) in Q4FY26. EBITDA fell about 76 per cent to ₹28.3 crore (vs. our estimate of ₹46 crore). In line with weak operating performance, APAT decreased about 74 per cent to ₹19.2 crore (against our estimate of ₹27.8 crore). The company's current order-book stands at about ₹8,670 crore, including ₹3,550 crore from the mining project. The road sector witnessed muted project awarding activity during FY26, with both MoRTH and NHAI showing slower award conversion despite a healthy pipeline of ₹3.5 lakh crore due to extended approval timelines and land acquisition challenges. KNRC delivered a disappointing performance yet again in Q4FY26, missing estimates by a wide margin as execution slowed due to a thin executable order-book. However, order awarding activity improved during the quarter, with KNR emerging as L1 in projects worth ₹3,230 crore. We expect revenue to improve only in FY28 as recently-won orders move into execution. We cut our earnings estimates for FY27 and FY28 by 8 per cent and 3 per cent, respectively, factoring in weak execution and expect revenue and EBITDA CAGR of 22 per cent and 45 per cent, respectively, over FY26-28. We reiterate our Neutral rating on the stock with our SoTP-based TP of ₹130.

InCred Equities

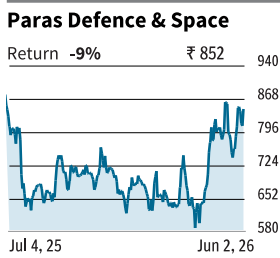
DEEPAK NITRITE (REDUCE) Target: ₹1,014 CMP: ₹1,683.20 Deepak Nitrite's ₹1,000-11,500 crore integrated polycarbonate capex is a large strategic bet, but the returns economics look weak. The timing of the capex is unfavourable, as China is adding capacity across polycarbonate, BPA (bisphenol A) and phenol. This is likely to push the value chain into oversupply and increase export pressure into import-dependent markets such as India. We do not see strong economic logic in building the full backward-integrated phenol-BPA-PC chain when China is already oversupplied in phenol and is moving into a large BPA surplus. China's BPA gross margin is already weak, phenol margin is barely positive, and about 700 kt of new BPA capacity is expected to come online. In this backdrop, importing BPA from China would likely have been more economical than committing large capital to captive BPA and phenol capacity in India. The company's peak debt is likely to rise to around ₹8,600 crore, changing the stock's historical low-leverage comfort. Interest costs may not pinch meaningfully for the next two years, but beyond that it is likely to impact P&L materially. Despite an expected 80 per cent increase in EBITDA in FY29F, higher interest costs and depreciation are likely to absorb most of the benefit, resulting in weak EBIT/PBT growth. Given this muted return trajectory, valuation remains lofty; we value the stock at 2x FY28F P/BV to arrive at a lower target price of ₹1,014 (₹1,515 earlier). Retain Reduce rating on the stock.

businessline is not responsible for the recommendations sourced from third party brokerages. Reports may be sent to: **blmarketwatch@gmail.com**

TODAY'S PICK.

Paras Defence & Space Tech (₹852.60): BUY

Gurumurthy K
bl. research bureau



The short-term outlook is bullish for Paras Defence & Space Technologies. The 4.6 per cent surge on Tuesday has happened after taking support from the 21-Day Moving Average (DMA), currently at ₹811. The region between ₹811 and ₹810 is a good support zone for now. There is a possible inverted head and shoulder formation visible on the chart. A break above ₹880 will confirm this pattern and take Paras Defence & Space Technologies share price up to ₹950 in the coming weeks. Traders can buy the stock now at ₹853. Accumulate on

dips at ₹820. Keep the stop-loss at ₹785 initially. Trail the stop-loss up to ₹865 as soon as the stock goes up to ₹890. Move the stop-loss higher to ₹885 and ₹910 when the price touches ₹905 and ₹925 respectively. Exit the long positions at ₹940. Note: The recommendations are based on technical analysis. There is a risk of loss in trading

Day trading guide

23606 » Nifty 50 Futures					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
23520	23480	23660	23720	Go long on dips at 23570 and 23540. Keep the stop-loss at 23490	

₹749 » HDFC Bank					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
745	738	754	764	Take fresh longs above 754. Keep the stop-loss at 752	

₹1268 » Infosys					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1260	1230	1280	1305	Go long only above 1280. Keep the stop-loss at 1270	

₹283 » ITC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
280	278	286	290	Wait for a rise. Go short at 285 with a stop-loss at 287	

₹266 » ONGC					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
264	261	269	272	Go long now and at 265. Stop-loss can be kept at 263	

₹1320 » Reliance Ind.					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
1310	1300	1330	1345	Go long only above 1330. Stop-loss can be placed at 1325	

₹960 » SBI					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
954	947	965	971	Wait for a rise. Go short at 964. Keep the stop-loss at 966	

₹2453 » TCS					
S1	S2	R1	R2	COMMENT	
2425	2385	2460	2520	Go long on a break above 2460. Keep the stop-loss at 2445	

S1, S2: Support 1 & 2; R1, R2: Resistance 1 & 2.

Nifty 50 Movers					▲ 100.95 pts.
	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)	
Infosys	1270.80	52.25	17.49	4.14	
TCS	2446.90	33.31	17.90	2.32	
HDFC Bank	748.25	18.53	14.54	10.64	
HCL Tech	1243.50	11.14	20.26	1.22	
ITC	283.25	7.57	16.88	2.54	
M&M	2998.30	5.48	20.02	2.49	
Adani Ports	1814.50	4.99	32.71	1.24	
Titan	4078.10	4.82	71.35	1.56	
Eternal Ltd	250.75	4.17	66.115	1.68	
Tech Mahindra	1571.40	3.37	32.34	0.93	
Adani Enter	2968.10	3.67	38.53	0.79	
Asian Paints	2660.70	2.79	58.07	1.12	
Kotak Bank	379.05	2.65	19.55	2.59	
Trent Ltd.	4210.40	2.57	86.95	0.87	
Tata Motors PV	390.20	2.42	4789.87	0.76	
Bharti Airtel	1814.20	2.41	32.68	5.17	
JSW Steel	1310.80	2.33	12.57	1.14	
State Bank	556.65	2.31	10.19	3.69	
Maruti Suzuki	13022.00	2.18	27.89	1.59	
Wipro	209.84	2.14	16.59	0.56	
Jio Financial Services Ltd.	237.64	1.92	96.72	0.72	
Hind Unilever	2093.70	1.82	46.49	1.73	
Max Healthcare	94.17	1.64	64.80	0.66	
DataConsumerProduct	1154.70	1.62	73.87	0.70	
Hindalco	1146.30	1.58	19.24	1.54	
Eicher Motors	7141.50	1.23	35.52	0.91	
NestleIndia	1398.70	1.08	77.08	0.93	
ONGC	265.05	0.64	6.70	0.96	
Hydrobhelvi	446.10	0.55	13.00	0.94	
Bharti Elec	407.85	0.51	40.49	1.36	
Tata Steel	210.60	0.05	24.15	1.62	
Coal India	472.15	-0.22	9.36	1.00	
Grasim Ind	3097.60	-0.42	20.47	1.10	
Apollo Hosp	8089.50	-0.43	58.08	0.77	
SBI Life	1801.70	-1.06	73.15	0.75	
Cipla	1279.30	-1.35	28.37	0.71	
Sun Pharma	1789.90	-1.52	37.32	1.76	
HDFC Life	579.90	-1.56	65.43	0.58	
UltraTech Cement	11165.00	-1.73	40.18	1.23	
Dr Reddys Lab	1274.00	-2.18	25.58	0.72	
Bajaj Finserv	1741.40	-2.20	14.17	0.93	
Shriram Finance Ltd.	911.70	-2.25	27.17	1.19	
Bajaj Auto	10281.00	-2.30	27.17	1.44	
L&T	4000.90	-2.54	29.04	4.36	
PowerGrid Corp	282.15	-3.95	16.48	1.19	
Bajaj Finance	882.00	-4.12	28.39	2.19	
Reliance Ind	1314.60	-7.96	18.58	8.25	
WIPAC	367.40	-11.69	12.93	1.62	
Axis Bank	1251.10	-14.53	14.65	3.34	
ICICI Bank	1226.60	-20.43	15.16	8.15	

Pts: Impact on index movement

Nifty Next 50 Movers

▲ 193.95 pts.

	Close(F)	Pts	PE	WN(%)
Varun Beverages .	537.00	44.43	56.59	2.96
Adani Power .	235.93	42.38	35.08	3.93
Sarmardhathersoninternat	144.89	38.98	37.43	2.58
Limindtree	4341.70	38.14	25.84	1.62
Indian Hotels Co.	661.65	36.93	41.91	2.34
Adani Energy Solutions .	1530.60	33.39	76.84	2.14
Cg Power & Ind Sol	907.70	25.86	119.45	2.51
United Spirits .	1275.00	21.85	49.67	1.52
DIF	591.85	21.37	33.19	1.53
Abb India	7146.00	17.55	95.83	1.51
Tvs Motor Cmp.	3366.90	14.92	50.20	3.18
Hindustaneronautics	4278.50	13.07	31.39	3.27
Bosch	37220.00	12.61	39.58	1.30
Solar Industries	18386.00	12.58	95.80	1.80
Canara Bank	129.08	10.66	6.55	1.75
Cummins India	5708.00	10.49	67.00	3.10
Macrotech Developers .	993.80	8.58	26.32	1.02
Gail (India)	164.83	8.30	14.29	1.79
Ambuja Cements	439.35	7.66	19.76	1.08
Bank Of Baroda	265.80	7.59	6.85	1.99
Muthootfin	3262.10	7.15	12.35	1.41
Mazagon Dock	2444.90	4.68	35.79	0.75
Siemens	3729.70	4.59	83.77	1.33
Punjab Nat Bank	104.09	3.02	6.48	2.44
AdaniGreenenergy	1449.40	2.37	120.15	1.96
Indian Railway Finance Corp	96.67	2.27	18.02	0.78
Union Bank	162.68	0.76	6.39	1.27
Indian Oilcorp	138.83	0.32	4.49	2.09
Tata Capital	300.75	-0.24	26.10	0.52
Hindus Zinc	625.10	-1.41	19.10	1.09
Pidilittind	1454.60	-2.28	59.92	1.82
Shree Cement	24995.00	-2.45	51.57	1.35
Bajaj Holdings	10240.00	-3.67	11.64	1.78
Hyundai Motor India .	1871.80	-4.27	28.00	0.77
Avenuesuper	4057.00	-6.15	88.89	2.40
Jindal Steel	1203.40	-6.69	36.53	1.79
Shree Cement	633.00	-7.35	67.58	3.44
JSDFinancials	1078.30	-9.11	21.18	1.09
Torrent Pharma	4317.90	-9.60	68.35	1.82
Godrej Consumer	999.10	-11.24	54.92	1.62
Hdfc Amc	2583.50	-11.29	38.72	2.12
Madhavanalamin&Fin	1482.80	-12.21	24.14	2.56
Adania Ind	511.70	-13.47	47.58	2.48
Bpd	294.40	-14.02	9.43	2.40
Vedanta	333.55	-17.72	8.22	2.28
Tata Motors	414.90	-21.74	25.91	2.80
Tata Motors Cv	370.55	-21.83	45.06	3.12
Rural Elec	32.05	-22.39	5.25	1.63
Power Grids Energy India	234.90	-23.49	98.51	1.29
Power Finance	413.05	-30.09	4.05	2.42

Pts: Impact on index movement

QUICKLY.

Netradyne, NHEV to deploy AI tech on e-highways

New Delhi: AI-powered fleet safety tech firm Netradyne has partnered with the National Highways for Electric Vehicles (NHEV) to introduce an intelligence and safety layer for commercial EVs operating on India's emerging e-highway network. The integration will provide real-time fleet visibility, predictive risk detection, driver behaviour insights, and operational monitoring for commercial EVs. m

India successfully tests RudraM-II missiles

New Delhi: The DRDO and the Indian Air Force have conducted the successful flight tests of RudraM-II air-to-surface missiles from an airborne platform, the Defence Ministry said on Tuesday. The missiles, after release, were guided to a predefined target with pin-point accuracy, it said, adding that all the test objectives were “fully” met. The range of the missile is around 350 km. m

Air cargo volumes rise, defying W. Asia turmoil; Chennai leads

BUCKING THE TREND. Driven by strong export demand and e-comm surge, international volumes soared 40%

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai

The volume of air freight handled by Indian airports remained resilient in April despite the West Asia crisis. The air cargo handled by air route registered growth in month-on-month and year-on-year (y-o-y) basis in April 2026.

According to Airports Authority of India (AAI) data, total freight handled at Indian airports was up from 3.15 lakh tonnes in April 2025 to 3.48 lakh tonnes in April 2026, a 10 per cent growth y-o-y. This was driven by a 40 per cent jump in international cargo volumes during the period.

CRISIS BUFFER

Similarly, the cargo handled in April was also marginally higher than the 3.43 lakh

Resilient supply chain (in tonnes)			
Total air freight handled			
	April 2026	April 2025	March 2026
International	2,20,702	1,56,808	2,08,134
Domestic	1,26,855	1,17,277	1,35,175
Total	3,47,557	3,15,115	3,43,309

Source: AAI

tonnes recorded in March 2026, the month when the war began. The growth comes at a time when airlines were forced to reroute flights to avoid conflict zones, resulting in longer flight times, higher fuel consumption, and increased operating costs. However, air cargo has remained relatively insulated from the impact of the crisis compared with maritime logistics.

Jagannarayan Padmanabhan, Senior Director & Global Head-Consulting, Crisil Intelligence, said part of the growth in interna-

tional air cargo is likely attributable to the rerouting of trade flows away from disrupted maritime corridors.

Sectors such as pharmaceuticals, electronics, engineering goods, perishables, automotive components and e-commerce, where delivery reliability is critical, appear to have relied on air freight.

Air transport is typically 5-7 times more expensive than sea freight.

Therefore, once maritime routes normalise, some of this cargo is expected to shift back to ocean transport, leading to a moderation in air

cargo growth rates, Padmanabhan said.

CK Govil, CMD of Delhi-based Activair Airfreight India, attributed the increase in air cargo volumes to a combination of strong export demand, expanding cross-border e-commerce and improved airline connectivity.

Some exporters and importers advanced shipments amid geopolitical uncertainties, while others shifted high-value and time-sensitive cargo to air transport to avoid disruptions and delays in maritime trade, he said.

CHENNAI LEADS

Chennai emerged as the fastest-growing airport during the January-April 2026 period, with volumes increasing from 32,896 tonnes in January to 38,295 tonnes in April, registering a growth of 16.4 per cent, the highest

among the top five airports.

Bengaluru recorded 8.5 per cent growth in the period, Hyderabad 8.4 per cent, Mumbai 8.3 per cent and Delhi 6.9 per cent.

Although Chennai remained the fourth-largest cargo airport in April behind Delhi, Mumbai and Bengaluru, its growth rate reflected the increasing importance of Tamil Nadu's manufacturing ecosystem.

J Krishnan of Chennai-based S Natesa Iyer Logistics said supply-chain disruptions and changing sourcing patterns have prompted a modal shift in India's export landscape. The production-linked incentive schemes, particularly in electronics and telecom manufacturing, have resulted in tighter production cycles and increased use of air freight for both inbound components and outbound finished products.

Computex 2026 signals dawn of agent-led personal computing

Rohan Das
Taipei, Taiwan

As the heavyweights of global tech converged upon Taipei, Taiwan, for Computex 2026, one message cut across the visionary keynotes and next-gen product announcements — a new era of personal computing is here.

The agentic era of computing will go beyond applications stuck inside devices to an all-pervasive agent which will work across various ‘endpoints’ from mobile phones and PCs to smartwatches, cars and household robots.

These agents will understand contexts, assess user needs, interact with other

similar agents and act autonomously with minimal human interference, the industry leaders declared at the annual technology conference.

Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang kicked off his keynote emphasising that the age of ‘useful AI’ has now arrived.

“Agents will not just be part of the cloud or within enterprises, it will run on our devices. Ten years from now, today's PCs will not exist. There will be an AI super-computer in every house which will run all of your agents who are doing all kinds of things for you all the time,” he said.

He also launched Nvidia's RTX Spark, the company's first real foray into CPUs by

the chip major known for its GPUs.

Purpose-built for PCs with personal agents, RTX Spark is expected to compete with similar offerings from Intel, AMD and Apple Silicon.

‘YEAR OF AGENTS’

Qualcomm's CEO Cristiano Amon described 2026 as the ‘year of agents’ and said that just like the smartphone has been central to digital life in the past two decades, in future, agents too will be the centre of digital experience.

He added that this evolution will require a complete reshaping of device architecture, with future devices having ‘two personalities’.

“One personality serves



Nvidia CEO Jensen Huang introduces the RTX Spark GPU on the sidelines of the annual Computex in Taipei REUTERS

the human user. The other serves the AI agent. Future devices will be used at the same time by both humans and agents working in the background,” he said.

Qualcomm, whose Snapdragon chip has been a fron-

trunner in on-device AI CPUs, launched Dragonfly, its umbrella brand for data centre compute. Interestingly, with this, Qualcomm now takes Nvidia head-on.

Meanwhile, Intel's Head, Lip Bu Tan, who wore the hat of a wise sage in comparison to his technology contemporaries, suggested that privacy will be another key driver for on-device AI.

Joined by Perplexity's Aravind Srinivas, Tan demonstrated a system of ‘hybrid agent inference’ where, within the same system, local agents on Intel chips will perform tasks with sensitive private data (like financial documents) while higher-level tasks will be done on cloud models.

In an interaction with *businessline*, David McAfee, who leads the products team for AMD's Ryzen processor family, said that globally, investments are being made and new fab capacities are being built to tackle the on-going memory crisis.

“Memory has historically gone through these mega cycles where prices get high because the market is undersupplied and then prices normalise when the market is oversupplied. We are on the undersupplied side of things now. It will take a few years for the capacity to catch up. But it's not a forever problem,” he said.

The writer is in Taipei at the invitation of Synology

With LNG 42% cheaper than diesel for truck ops, freight sector seeks ethanol-style policy intervention

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai

As the freight sector grapples with high fuel costs, LNG is emerging as one of the cheapest fuels for long-haul trucking, costing nearly 42 per cent less than diesel and materially cheaper than CNG for generating the same transport work.

At current fuel prices, transport work that costs a fleet operator roughly ₹146.75 on diesel can be done for about ₹85 using LNG, while the same work on CNG costs anywhere between ₹96 and ₹110, depending on the city.

That gives LNG a 12-23 per cent advantage over CNG, whose economics have weakened after recent price hikes linked to rising global gas prices and cuts in cheaper domestic gas allocation.



COST ADVANTAGE. At current fuel prices, transport work that costs a fleet operator roughly ₹146.75 on diesel can be done for about ₹85 using LNG REUTERS

Yet despite the economics turning favourable, India's LNG trucking ecosystem remains underdeveloped.

POLICY SUPPORT

Vadodara-based cryogenic engineering company INOX-CVA has approached the Ministry of Petroleum & Natural Gas seeking ethanol-style policy support for LNG infrastructure, storage and freight-corridor development. The pitch comes as In-

dia previously approved ₹4,573 crore in support for ethanol distilleries and helped mobilise nearly ₹40,000 crore in private investment for blending infrastructure.

“The success of the ethanol programme demonstrates what can be achieved when policy, infrastructure and industry work together towards a common national objective,” Deepak Acharya, Managing Director at INOX-

CVA, told *businessline*. “Historically, LNG adoption has been constrained more by infrastructure availability than economics.”

Industry executives argue LNG's challenge is no longer affordability but ecosystem readiness. Unlike CNG trucks that require bulky cylinder cascades and more frequent refuelling, LNG trucks can travel longer distances using compact cryogenic tanks, improving payload efficiency for interstate freight operations.

DIESEL INFLATION

The economics are also becoming harder to ignore as road freight carries nearly two-thirds of India's domestic cargo, meaning sustained diesel inflation eventually feeds into broader logistics, manufacturing and retail costs.

Unlike ethanol infrastructure, which benefited from

direct policy support, LNG infrastructure expansion is currently being driven largely by private capital.

GreenLine Mobility has committed ₹1,500 crore towards LNG and EV trucks and fuel stations, while Ultra Gas & Energy Ltd is investing around ₹900 crore to build 100 LNG dispensing outlets across freight corridors.

INOXCVA's proposal goes beyond trucking economics and introduces an energy-security layer. The company argued India lacks strategic LNG reserves similar to its crude petroleum reserves, leaving the gas economy exposed to geopolitical disruptions. Its white paper proposes a decentralised network of 10 mini-LNG terminals capable of adding nearly 200,000 cubic metres of strategic LNG storage capacity through a public-private partnership model.

NephroPlus expects 15-20% CAGR in revenue over three years: CEO

bl.interview

G Naga Sridhar
Hyderabad

As Asia's largest dialysis care provider, Nephrocare Health Services (NephroPlus) is sharpening its focus on scale and digital innovation to transform dialysis delivery. FY26 marked a milestone as NephroPlus became a listed company.

In an interaction, Group CEO Rohit Singh spoke about the company's growth plans and industry trends.

Edited excerpts:

How do you assess the dialysis market opportunity and where does NephroPlus stand? Chronic kidney disease (CKD) is rising rapidly due to the growing prevalence of diabetes and hypertension,

which affects 14-15 per cent of the population. Currently, India has around 3 lakh active dialysis patients, but this represents only 10-12 per cent of the actual need.

The real prevalence is estimated to be 7-10 times higher, indicating a significant unmet demand. However, government initiatives such as Ayushman Bharat and various State-sponsored health schemes are improving access. NephroPlus, which started with a single centre in Hyderabad 16 years ago, now operates 445 centres in India, with 72-74 per cent located in tier-2 and tier-3 cities.

What is driving NephroPlus' international expansion strategy?

International operations are a major growth engine for us. NephroPlus currently oper-

““

We expect industry consolidation, wider coverage, stronger standards and greater home dialysis adoption over the next five years

ROHIT SINGH

Group CEO, NephroPlus



ates in five countries — India, Philippines, Uzbekistan, Nepal and Saudi Arabia. The company follows a three-pronged growth strategy: Expanding patient volumes in existing centres, increasing centre count in current markets, and entering new geographies through acquisitions, partnerships or government contracts.

The Philippines has grown from six centres (at acqui-

sition) to 44 clinics, while Uzbekistan now has six centres. The company is evaluating opportunities in South-East Asia, CIS countries and, over time, select European markets.

Beyond dialysis, do you see opportunities in adjacent healthcare segments?

NephroPlus remains focused on renal care and dialysis ser-

vices, a global market estimated at \$80 billion. However, the company is evaluating technology-led preventive care solutions to slow the progression of CKD from early to end-stage renal disease.

What are your growth plans and outlook over the next few years?

International operations contribute about 40 per cent of revenues, up from 32 per cent earlier, reflecting higher treatment realisations in overseas markets. Dialysis treatment costs around \$110 in the Philippines and \$64 in Uzbekistan, compared with roughly \$22 in India. The company expects to sustain 15-20 per cent revenue CAGR over the next three to four years. It continues to add 40-50 centres annually and is well-funded, with around ₹500 crore in cash

following its IPO. Over the next five years, the management expects greater industry consolidation, wider insurance and government coverage, stronger quality standards and accreditation systems and increased adoption of home dialysis.

NephroPlus already serves nearly 100 home-dialysis patients and sees this segment gaining traction as affordability improves.

How important are government-backed schemes to NephroPlus' business model?

About 30 per cent of our revenue comes from public-private partnership projects, while another 30 per cent comes through government-funded healthcare schemes.

The remaining 35-40 per cent comes from private insurance and direct patient payments.

Diesel vehicles see market shrink 16%; CNG and EVs gain

Amit Vijay Mohile
Mumbai



Alternative fuel vehicles — CNG, EVs and strong hybrids — accounted for 32.1 per cent of passenger vehicle sales in May 2026, up from 27.2 per cent a year earlier.

In contrast, the combined share of petrol and diesel vehicles declined to 67.9 per cent from 72.9 per cent over the same period, marking a nearly 500 basis-point shift in India's fuel mix within a year.

However, contrary to expectations that fuel-price hikes would boost demand for premium fuel-efficient cars, strong hybrid vehicles lost market share in May even as diesel's share in the market fell over 16 per cent year-on-year (y-o-y), according to Vahan data.

One in three cars sold in India now runs on CNG, electric or hybrid technology, signalling a rapid shift towards lower running-cost mobility options as fuel prices and operating economics increasingly shape vehicle purchase decisions.

The transition, however, is currently being dominated more by CNG than pure electrification.

LOW RUNNING COSTS

CNG vehicles alone accounted for 23.5 per cent of total passenger vehicle sales in May, up from 22.2 per cent in April and 19.9 per cent a year earlier, highlighting how buyers are increasingly prioritising lower running costs amid rising fuel prices.

EVs accounted for 6.6 per cent of total passenger vehicle sales in May, up from 6.1 per cent in April and 4.6 per cent a year earlier.

Strong hybrids, meanwhile, slipped to 2 per cent market share in May from 2.3 per cent in April and 2.7 per cent a year earlier, suggest-

ing that higher fuel prices are not yet pushing mass-market consumers toward premium hybrid vehicles.

Passenger vehicle retail sales declined 6.3 per cent month-on-month to 3.96 lakh units in May from 4.22 lakh units in April, although the market remained up 23 per cent y-o-y over last year's lower base.

FUEL PREFERENCE

Hemal Thakkar, Senior Director & Senior Practice Leader, Crisil Intelligence, said the transition was increasingly being driven by operating economics rather than fuel preference alone.

“EV penetration has improved to 6.6 per cent in May from 6.1 per cent in April. Compared with around 4.6 per cent in the same period last year, that's nearly a 200 basis-point jump year-on-year,” he said.

Saket Mehra, Partner and Automotive & EV Industry Leader at Grant Thornton Bharat, said the market was witnessing a calibrated normalisation rather than a structural demand slowdown, although rising fuel prices were beginning to influence consumer sentiment across the automotive sector. Vinkesh Gulati, Chairman of the Automotive Skills Development Council, said the ‘one-in-three-cars’ shift was being driven more by affordability than technology sophistication, explaining why CNG vehicles were gaining faster than strong hybrids despite recent CNG price hikes.

Airtel's new Priority plans do not violate net neutrality norms: TRAI assessment

Press Trust of India
New Delhi



Telecom Regulatory Authority of India's (TRAI) early assessment indicates that recently announced Priority Postpaid plans of Bharti Airtel that leverage 5G network slicing do not violate net neutrality norms, a source said.

TRAI is, however, closely examining the issue to see whether ‘slicing a chunk’ to offer better service to certain postpaid customers deteriorates the quality of service offered to the remaining 5G subscribers.

DATA CLARIFICATIONS

The regulator, which is also seeking more information from Airtel, has asked the operator to furnish data and clarifications related to the quality of service. No specific deadline has been fixed for completing the detailed ex-

amination, and continuous monitoring will take place.

For now, preliminary assessment has not shown any reason for immediate concern, the source said, adding that Bharti Airtel's Priority Postpaid plans do not violate net neutrality norms.

Airtel has conveyed to TRAI that the offering leverages 5G network slicing to deliver an enhanced service experience to postpaid customers without degrading the service of any other customer.

Airtel has said the Priority Postpaid plan has been implemented in a content-

neutral manner. Last month, Airtel launched ‘Priority Postpaid’ plans promising consistent speed even in crowded markets for postpaid customers. The plan sparked debate on whether such offerings violate the rules of the net neutrality framework.

NETWORK SLICING

The telecom services provider promises that 5G Priority Postpaid will provide a ‘fast lane’ to subscribers with the use of network slicing technology, even during peak traffic time, by dynamically separating a portion of the network for them from other categories of telecom services.

On May 26, a parliamentary committee sought answers from the Department of Telecommunications and the TRAI to review the impact of 5G network slicing services in Singapore, the UK and a few other nations.

Blackstone closes record \$13 billion Asia PE fund

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Blackstone has announced the close of its third Asian private equity fund, pulling in \$13.1 billion in commitments. The fund, Blackstone Capital Partners Asia III, surpassed its initial \$10 billion target to hit its hard cap.

The oversubscribed vehicle stands as Blackstone's largest-ever private equity fundraise dedicated to the Asia-Pacific region. Highlighting a surge in investor demand for regional exposure, the capital raised more than doubles the amount secured for the strategy's predecessor fund.

Company executives pointed to the region's strong macroeconomic tail-

winds as a key driver for the fundraise.

“Asia Pacific is presenting compelling opportunities to invest at scale behind our high-conviction themes,” said Joe Baratta, Global Head of Blackstone Private Equity Strategies, adding that the successful close reflects the firm's ability to perform across market cycles.

FOCUS ON SCALE

Amit Dixit, Blackstone's Head of Asia for Private Equity, said the firm's differentiation relies on its scale, homegrown regional teams, and a strategy that prioritises hands-on business transformations. The close follows a busy 24-month stretch for the firm in Asia, particularly in its primary hubs of India and Japan.

QUICKLY.

RBI to conduct two-day VRR auction on June 3



Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) on Tuesday said it will conduct a two-day variable rate repo (VRR) auction of ₹50,000 crore on June 3. The auction will take place between 9.30 am and 10 am, and the reversal of these funds will take place on June 5. Currently, liquidity in the banking system is estimated to be in surplus of around ₹85,411.44 crore as of June 1, which has narrowed from a surplus of ₹1.4 lakh crore on May 31. **BT**

IOB secures IFSCA licence for GIFT City branch

Chennai: Indian Overseas Bank on Tuesday said the International Financial Services Centres Authority (IFSCA), via a letter dated June 1, had granted license to set up its branch at GIFT City, Gujarat. This will enable the bank to participate in global offshore banking and foreign currency operations. This development comes on the heels of the IOB's board-approved plan to raise ₹5,000 crore in fresh capital. **OUR BUREAU**

Proportion of bank loans with less than 9% interest surges

BORROWINGS UP. The household sector accounts for 58.6% of total bank credit

Our Bureau
Mumbai

The proportion of Scheduled Commercial Banks' (SCBs) loans bearing interest rate of less than 9 per cent rose sharply in FY26 to 64.2 per cent as on end-March 2026 from 43.9 per cent a year ago, in sync with the easing cycle, according to the RBI.

The RBI noted that in response to the cumulative 125 bps reduction in the policy repo rate (from 6.5 per cent to 5.25 per cent), SCBs adjusted both repo-linked external benchmark-based lending rates (EBLRs) and marginal cost of funds-based lending rates (MCLR) downward during February 2025 to March 2026.

"The pass-through to weighted average lending rates (WALRs) has been robust. The transmission to lending rates on fresh and outstanding loans has been broad-based across sectors," per the RBI's latest monthly bulletin.

The transmission of the repo rate cuts to external benchmark-based lending rate (EBLR)-linked new floating rate personal or retail loans (housing, auto,



MORE WOMEN USE CREDIT. Share of individuals in total bank credit was at 47.8% as of end-March 2026. Of this, women borrowers stood at 24.7% as against 23.8% a year ago **GETTY IMAGES**

etc.) and floating rate loans to micro, small and medium enterprises extended by banks has been one-to-one.

PSU BANKS

Transmission of the repo rate cuts to loans linked to the marginal cost of funds-based lending rate (MCLR) has been gradual, with the weighted average lending rate on fresh and outstanding rupee loans declining 93 bps and 88 bps, respectively.

Public sector banks saw higher credit growth than the headline credit growth of 14.1 per cent as on end-March 2026. Bank credit growth year-on-year (y-o-y) was up 14.1 per cent (11.1 per cent).

Private sector banks saw an increase in credit growth (y-o-y) to 12.3 per cent (lower than the banking system's credit growth of 14.1 per cent).

"Small finance banks expanded their total credit share to 1.6 per cent from 1 per cent in March 2021," per the RBI's statement on SCBs' Annual Basic Statistical Return (BSR) on Credit.

Personal loans growth (y-o-y) moderated to 12.9 per cent as on end-March 2026, falling below overall credit growth after consistently outpacing it over the past several years. The share of personal loans, including housing, education, vehicle, personal credit cards, con-

sumer durables and other personal loans, within total credit stood at 30.7 per cent, per the statement.

Loans to the private corporate sector accounted for over one-fourth of total bank credit and grew (y-o-y) by 15.5 per cent as on end-March 2026.

Credit growth (y-o-y) in the agriculture and industrial sectors increased to 14.4 per cent and 12 per cent, respectively, as on end-March 2026, from 8.1 per cent and 9.4 per cent a year ago. Their shares in total bank credit stood at 12.9 per cent and 22.4 per cent, respectively.

HOUSEHOLD SECTOR

The RBI noted that borrowings by the household sector increased by 14.3 per cent (y-o-y). The sector accounted for 58.6 per cent of total bank credit. Share of individuals in total bank credit was at 47.8 per cent as on end-March 2026. Within this, female borrowers stood at 24.7 per cent (23.8 per cent).

Term loans accounted for 62.8 per cent of total bank credit. Of this, the share of loans bearing interest rates of less than 10 per cent stood at 80.2 per cent.

Rupee set to consolidate

Akhil Nallamuthu
bl. research bureau

The rupee continued its recovery and appreciated about 0.4 per cent (42 paise) over the past week to close at 95.27 against the dollar on Tuesday. The local currency has now recovered about 1.7 per cent from the record low of 96.96 it touched on May 20.

WEEKLY RUPEE VIEW.

The rebound comes despite continued foreign outflows. According to NSDL data, net FPI outflows stood at about \$2.3 billion over the past week. However, the pressure from outflows was offset by a sharp correction in crude oil prices. Brent crude futures (\$94/barrel) slumped 12 per cent last week, reducing concerns over India's import bill and offering support to the rupee.

Notably, the recovery has come even as the dollar index remained largely flat over the past two weeks. This suggests that domestic factors have also contributed to the rupee's gains.

Economic data released recently indicate resilience in the domestic economy. Supported by a 6.2 per cent growth in manufacturing, India's Index of Industrial Production (IIP) expanded 4.9



per cent in April, compared with 3.2 per cent in the preceding month. Additionally, the Centre managed to contain the fiscal deficit at 4.4 per cent of GDP in FY26, in line with its target, and has set a lower target of 4.3 per cent for FY27.

That said, uncertainty surrounding West Asia continues to linger. While fresh military exchanges involving Iran and Israel have kept markets cautious, diplomatic efforts remain active. US President Donald Trump recently expressed optimism about reaching an agreement with Iran to extend the truce and reopen the Strait of Hormuz.

Overall, easing crude prices and resilient domestic indicators have aided the rupee, although geopolitical developments remain a key risk.

CHART

The rupee has witnessed a notable recovery in recent sessions. After touching a three-week high of 94.75 on Monday, it has moderated

to 95.27. The chart indicates that 95 is a key resistance level.

A breakout above 95 can extend the recovery towards 94.50 and subsequently to 94.20. On the other hand, if the local currency weakens from the current level, it can find support at 95.75 and 96. The next support below 96 is at 96.25.

In the near term, the rupee is likely to move sideways, in line with the prevailing trend in the dollar index.

Since May 18, the dollar index has been oscillating within the 98.90-99.50 range. The direction of the breakout from this band will likely determine the next leg of the trend. A breach of 99.50 can lift the index to 100.50, whereas a break below 98.90 can drag it to 98.

Therefore, if the dollar index rallies to 100.50, the rupee could weaken towards 96.25. Conversely, a decline in the index to 98 may help the local currency appreciate towards 94.20.

OUTLOOK

Overall, the rupee appears to have entered a consolidation phase after the recent recovery. In the near term, the local currency is likely to trade within the 95-96 range, with the next directional move depending largely on which side does the dollar index breaks out of the 98.90-99.50 band.

Essar-backed Mesabi Metalics sells half of royalty interest for \$265 million

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

Essar Group-backed Mesabi Metalics has agreed to sell 50 per cent stake in its royalty interest to The Metals Royalty Company (TMCR) for \$265 million in a transaction that values the royalty platform at over \$500 million and provides fresh capital, as the US iron ore project approaches production.

The transaction will be completed in two tranches of \$132.5 million each, with the first closing on June 1 and the second expected within 60 days.

Mesabi stated that most of

the proceeds will be used to support growth initiatives.

"The transaction further validates the exceptional quality, scale and long-term strategic importance of Mesabi Metalics' world-class Direct Reduction (DR) grade iron ore mine, beneficiation plant and pellet plant in Minnesota, which is expected to commence production in the third quarter of 2026," it said.

IMPORT DEPENDENCE

Once operational, Mesabi is expected to become one of the few significant domestic suppliers of merchant DR-grade iron ore pellets in North America, a key raw

material used in electric arc furnace steelmaking. The project is positioned to reduce US dependence on imported DR-grade iron ore, particularly from Brazil and other overseas suppliers.

The royalty transaction follows more than \$670 million of recently announced financing commitments, including \$520 million from Breakwall Capital and \$150 million from Macquarie Group. Mesabi has also secured an indication of support of up to \$10 billion from the Export-Import Bank of the United States (EXIM), highlighting growing investor and institutional backing for the project.

Alkem rolls out pre-filled syringes of semaglutide

Our Bureau
Mumbai

Alkem Laboratories has brought in semaglutide in single-shot pre-filled syringes in multiple dose strengths starting at ₹350, the company said.

The company had received the regulatory Drugs Controller General of India's approval for the manufacture and marketing of semaglutide pre-filled syringes for type-2 diabetes and obesity, the company said.

MORE OPTIONS

The one shot pre-filled syringe format expands treatment options for patients and lowers entry barriers by



A PRECEDENT. Semaglutide is the active ingredient in Novo Nordisk's Ozempic and weight-loss drug Wegovy **GETTY IMAGES**

making it affordable, it added.

Semaglutide is the active ingredient in Novo Nordisk's diabetes drug Ozempic and weight-loss drug Wegovy.

A host of generic drug-makers with their less expensive versions of the product entered the market

for semaglutide vials, which will be launched soon, it added.

PRACTICAL DRUG

Dr Vikas Gupta, Alkem's outgoing Chief Executive Officer, said, "Semaglutide has the potential to change how we manage metabolic disorders."

"In India, where we are seeing a continuous rise in disease burden, offering multiple, practical drug delivery formats is an important step in helping more patients start and stay on the therapy," he added.

Several local drugmakers including Sun Pharma, Torrent Pharma, Zyudus and Dr Reddy's Laboratories, for example, are in the fray.

West Asia crisis likely to shrink MSME margins by 50-100 bps in FY27, says Crisil

Our Bureau
Chennai

The West Asia conflict will likely shave 100 bps off Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises (MSME) revenue this fiscal (FY27), and the margins are expected to shrink 50-100 bps, a Crisil analysis has found.

The Morbi, Firozabad, Surat and Vadodara clusters are likely to be hit the most, according to projections in Crisil Intelligence's latest MSME Report.

Revenue growth will moderate to 7.5-8.5 per cent, down 100 basis points (bps) compared with fiscal 2026,



DUE TO EXIGENCIES. Units heavily reliant on energy inputs, particularly those with limited access to gas or lower ability to switch to alternative fuels, may be hit the hardest **SRIRAM MA**

while earnings before interest, tax, depreciation and amortisation (EBITDA) margin will decline 50-100 bps to

5-5.5 per cent, stated the report.

The study covers 69 sectors and 147 MSME clusters.

The forecasts would have been more subdued but for the domestic gems and jewellery market, which is experiencing a value-led expansion, driven by a surge in gold prices, the report added.

The West Asia crisis is following a similar pattern as Covid, with small businesses bearing a disproportionate burden, the research firm noted.

"MSMEs face a dual challenge this time: first, production cuts and revenue losses due to reduced availability of raw material such as gas and, second, margin compression stemming from trade disruptions and limited pricing power to pass on increasing

commodity and energy costs," it said.

ENERGY INPUTS

Units heavily reliant on energy inputs, particularly those in clusters with limited access to gas or lower ability to switch to alternative fuels, are estimated to be hit the hardest.

The Morbi cluster, which accounts for over 80 per cent of India's ceramic tile production, is a case in point. With 80-85 per cent of its production gas-based, MSMEs which generate over 85 per cent of the cluster's ceramic sector revenue will see revenue growth plummet from 9-11 per cent in

fiscal 2026 to 1-3 per cent in fiscal 2027. This is largely due to export-oriented production (80-90 per cent of output) nature, with 20-25 per cent of exports directed to West Asia.

Similarly, Firozabad's glass sector has seen a 40 per cent production reduction, with MSMEs likely to experience only 1-3 per cent revenue growth. "The chemical sector, which imports over 90 per cent of its key inputs such as methanol, from West Asia, has seen raw material prices surge 1.2-1.4x with partial pass-on. Thus, chemical MSMEs in Vadodara are expected to witness a margin decline of 150-250 bps to 3-5

per cent in FY27. In Surat's textile sector, raw material costs, particularly for polyester yarn and fibre, which are crude derivatives, have surged, further squeezing already thin margins," Pushan Sharma, Director, Crisil Intelligence, said in a statement.

To mitigate the impact, the Union Cabinet has approved a scheme under the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme 5.0. However, its effectiveness in stabilising the MSME sector will depend on the quality, speed and inclusiveness of its implementation and execution mechanisms, Crisil said.

SBI Chairman, Apple India MD among 29 trade board members

Press Trust of India
New Delhi

The government on Tuesday said it has nominated 29 non-official members, including SBI Chairman CS Setty, Apple India MD Virat Bhatia, and Mahindra & Mahindra MD Anish Shah, to the Board of Trade, chaired by the Commerce and Industry Minister.

Other members include Sunita Ramnathkar, President, IMC Chamber of Commerce and Industry; Satish Goel, President, All India Rice Exporters Association; Vikrampati Singhania, President, Automobile Components Manufacturers Association; Sanjay Nayyar, Founder, Sorin Investments; Prashanth Prakash, Partner, Accel; Puran Dawar, Chairman and Founder, Dawar Group; and Shashi Kiran, Founder & Executive Chairman, Allcargo Group.

Others include Vaibhav Vohra, Group MD, Continental Carriers; Dilip Oommen, CEO, ArcelorMittal Nippon Steel; Sandeep Somany, Chairman and MD, Somany Impressa Group; Shailesh Chandra, President SIAM and MD & CEO, Tata Motors; Haigreve Khaitan, Managing Partner, Khaitan & Co; Satish Reddy, Chairperson, Dr Reddy's Laboratories Ltd; Parth Jindal, MD, JSW Cements; and Shridhar Vembu, Co-founder, Zoho Corporation.

AWS does not use water to cool its data centres, says India & South Asia chief Sandeep Dutta

bl.interview

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Amazon Web Services has identified India as its key market and is investing \$12.7 billion in local cloud infrastructure in the country by 2030. This comes even as the competitive landscape in enterprise cloud and data centre infrastructure has intensified in the last few years.

In his first interview since taking over as AWS President for India and South Asia, Sandeep Dutta underlined his key focus areas, why he is bullish, and plans to build 'from India for India and the world'.

Edited excerpts:

Where does India sit in terms of global priorities for AWS and the market?

India remains a very strategic market for AWS. Our success with AI will depend on how much we can democratise technology so that every person can start using, consuming and creating AI.

India is one of only six countries globally where AWS has two regions in the same country and is fully stacked with all the features for strategic and potential demand. The next few years are actually going to be very exciting for us.

AWS had announced billions in investments in India. Are you exceeding the rate at which you will spend the announced investments?

We should be 400-450 megawatts or thereabouts of capacity that is already needed.

In terms of the investment trajectory, we will probably exceed. The numbers are pretty large.

Where are you seeing the opportunity as of now? Where is the ROI for technologies like AI?

We have to continuously push and get customers to focus on an industry-specific problem that they are going to solve rather than focusing on the technology, because the technology is a means to the end, not the end.

We have to get them out of this proof-of-concept fatigue and towards investing in cases that are being put into production. With the cost of technology constantly coming down, they should adopt the mentality of failing fast and learning faster.

As they become more comfortable with AI, they will eventually get to the right answer, but it also depends on how the AI agenda is driven within an organisation. Is it a CDO or CTO conversation, or is it a CEO conversation?

Amazon has invested more than ₹42 crore (\$4.3 million) in water replenishment efforts across India to restore over 3 billion litres of water annually

SANDEEP DUTTA
President, AWS India and South Asia

Do you see the same evolution in AI with what happened to cloud where you had to seed-in ideas and help them get into that adoption and see the benefits before they go big scale?

We are. As AWS, it is also our responsibility to build that whole landscape. Through our partner landscape, we are working to help our cus-



tomers identify real problems and convince them to invest, and I am seeing a change.

Could you point out a specific largescale cloud or AI product engineered by your India R&D team that you have opened up to your global clients?

I will talk about use cases. If you see UPI, the number of UPI transactions that we

have as a country is second to none: 21 billion UPI transactions monthly.

Today, the question being asked by every bank is can their core banking applications keep pace with the rising volumes of UPI transactions?

Kotak partnered with us and created the augmented core strategy, where they have created a meta layer on top of the core banking infrastructure.

They have been able to bring the latency down by one-fifth in a scenario where they are handling more than one billion UPI transactions monthly. There are other examples as well in terms of AI latency, like DigiYatra.

So, is this because anything that India does is volume-based, scale-based and cost-effective? It is citizen scale, impact and cost. If you affect something

in India at that scale, putting it to use in any other market or customer, the road will only be that much more easy because our proof of concept also typically runs into millions.

There's a narrative from the US that a lot of the data centres consume large amounts of water and power. Will India face the same situation? Is water going to be an issue?

On the back of investments that we are making in India, we have renewable power purchase agreements, which are to the tune of 1.3 gigawatts.

Amazon has invested more than ₹42 crore (\$4.3 million) in water replenishment efforts across India to restore over 3 billion litres of water annually.

We don't use water when cooling our data centres. Our ambient DC temperature

will be slightly higher than some of the others, but we provide still the best optimal output when it comes to services.

JioCloud is entering the data centre space. How do you assess this telco-backed hyperscaler with a nationalist narrative?

We look forward to competition. On sovereignty, we are sovereign by design. We have no access to the data customers put on our infrastructure. They decide where and how the data needs to be stored and secured.

We comply with MeitY and are very clear that responsible AI is core and central to what we do.

When customers see that the data is secure, their AI is auditable and their cloud service provider is compliant and in panel, it creates the right trust framework for them to invest big.

QUICKLY.

Sarovar Hotels optimistic about Africa business



Mumbai: Sarovar Hotels expects its new hotel in Uganda to stabilise in the coming months and remains optimistic about overall growth from its Africa business, despite the Ebola outbreak in the Democratic Republic of Congo. The chain is banking on domestic and intra-Africa travel for growth as global demand remains muted due to travel advisories and restrictions. Sarovar Hotels opened a 90-key property under the Portico brand at Kampala in Uganda last month. It also runs hotels in Kenya, Zambia and Somaliland. “While Uganda is witnessing a temporary impact on international travel sentiment, the hospitality sector is optimistic about recovery driven by resilient domestic demand and the industry’s adaptive approach,” a spokesperson said. **OUR BUREAU**

Despite tough Q4, FLY91 targets fleet expansion to 12 aircraft by FY27-end

FLYING HIGH. Healthy fuel-to-revenue ratio achieved by the airline’s all-ATR fleet keeps mood optimistic

Rohit Vaid
New Delhi

Regional airline FLY91 plans to expand its fleet to 10-12 aircraft by the end of FY27 from the six currently, said Manoj Chacko, Managing Director and Chief Executive Officer of the airline. The development assumes significance as the venture remains the only start-up airline in recent years to have not only survived but also expanded in the country’s highly challenging and competitive aviation environment. Speaking to *businessline*, Chacko said the additional aircraft induction till FY27-end will allow it to deploy capacity across the airline’s two operating bases in Goa and Hyderabad as it expands its regional network. The airline’s immediate expansion plans, he said, are

centred around strengthening connectivity from its existing bases, with a long-term plan of pursuing a multi-base national network strategy. Apart from operating regional routes from Goa and Hyderabad to tier-1 and tier-2 cities, the airline plans to add flights to Mumbai, contingent upon slot availability. FLY91 also plans to add other destinations, including Tirupati, Mangaluru, Bogapuram and Indore, from its Goa and Hyderabad bases by the end of the current financial year. At present, the airline operates a fleet of six ATR 72-600 aircraft. **SIMPLER OPS** The turboprop seats up to 72 passengers and is known for its fuel efficiency and operational flexibility, making it suitable for regional operations.



WIDENING NETWORK. At present, the airline operates a fleet of six ATR 72-600 aircraft with bases in Goa and Hyderabad

According to Chacko, operating an exclusively ATR fleet has enabled the airline to maintain a simpler operation while achieving a healthy fuel-to-revenue ratio. “The industry continues to grapple with elevated fuel costs. However, our ATR operations allow us to maintain a fuel-to-revenue ratio of 20-22 per cent, compared with 38-40 per cent for operators using jet aircraft,” he said. Besides, the airline’s digital presence and marketing strategy have helped ensure a steady flow of passengers, thereby enhancing route viability. **GOVERNMENT SUPPORT** The airline is looking forward to the modified UDAN scheme, while maintaining that it operates largely as an independent carrier with minimal support through viability gap funding (VGF) under the regional connectivity programme.

Adani scales up capex to record ₹1.53 lakh cr despite modest growth

Our Bureau
Ahmedabad



The group’s portfolio EBITDA rose to an all-time high of ₹94,834 crore in FY26

The Adani Group ramped up capital expenditure to a record ₹1.53 lakh crore in FY26 — the highest annual investment by any Indian corporate — as it accelerated spending across airports, renewable energy, transmission, roads and logistics, even as core operating profit growth remained relatively modest at 5.6 per cent. The group’s portfolio EBITDA rose to an all-time high of ₹94,834 crore in FY26 from ₹89,806 crore a year earlier, while its asset base expanded to ₹7.85 lakh crore. Earnings growth, however, was tempered by declines at several major businesses, including a 28.6 per cent drop in EBITDA from Adani Enterprises’ existing businesses, a 12.2 per cent decline at Adani Cement and a 2.5 per cent fall at Adani Power. The numbers highlight the challenge facing the conglomerate as it embarks on its largest-ever investment cycle. Nearly 80 per cent of the spending was directed towards core infrastructure platforms spanning energy, utilities, transport and logistics, with many of the newly-created assets yet to make a meaningful contribution to earnings.

COST OF BORROWING The average cost of borrowing declined to 7.8 per cent in FY26 from 9 per cent two years ago, supported by rating upgrades across group companies. According to the company, all Adani portfolio assets now carry domestic credit ratings of A- or higher. Among the major business verticals, transport emerged as the strongest performer with EBITDA rising 23.2 per cent to ₹25,228 crore, driven by growth in cargo volumes and logistics operations. Infrastructure businesses housed under Adani Enterprises posted EBITDA growth of 13.8 per cent, while utility businesses, which account for the largest share of group earnings, reported a 4.6 per cent increase. The utility, transport and infrastructure segments together contributed ₹82,083 crore, or about 87 per cent of the portfolio’s EBITDA, underscoring the group’s increasing reliance on long-gestation infrastructure assets as the primary driver of earnings.

‘Zee got media rights for FIFA events for under \$60 m’

Vallari Sanzgiri
Mumbai

Zee Entertainment has bagged FIFA rights for 39 global football events at a reported valuation of under \$60 million, broadening the scope of sports revenue beyond cricket. “Zee has likely won FIFA rights at reported valuation of under \$60 million which is lower than ₹4.5 billion paid by Viacom 18/Reliance Media Co for FIFA World Wup 2022,” said CLSA capital markets in its report, anticipating the potential fan-following and advertiser build-up from the deal.

Zee is now sitting on an eight-year contract with the Federation Internationale de Football Association or FIFA for one of the most loved sports in the world, at a sum much lower than the Indian Premier League’s (IPL) media rights deal of \$6.2 billion for 2023-27. The FIFA World Cup remains one of the most premium global media properties, catching the attention of youth brands particularly in technology, smartphones, auto, fintech, e-commerce and gaming categories, as per sources. “For advertisers, FIFA (World Cup) is perhaps the biggest test yet of whether



India has matured into a multi-sport media market or remains overwhelmingly dependent on cricket,” said Umair Mohammad, Founder & CEO at Nitro Commerce. Even so, the 2026 FIFA World Cup is expected to generate over \$6 billion in global revenues, making it

the biggest tournament in history. The World Cup encompasses 48 teams and 104 matches, significantly increasing inventory for broadcasters and advertisers alike. With a claim to the media rights of 39 such events until 2034, Zee now has a differentiated platform to attract both audiences and advertisers. **ADVERTISER BUZZ** Media agencies speaking to *businessline* noted reactions from advertisers a day after the deal announcement. “Football has steadily built a passionate fan base in India, especially among younger urban audiences,”

said Raghu Khanna, Founder and CEO of CASHurDRIVE Marketing, an outdoor advertising agency. Having worked with the Punjab Kings franchise during the IPL, Khanna said brands today are looking beyond reach towards fan engagement and community building. “The FIFA rights strengthen the competitive landscape in India’s sports media market. They provide advertisers with an alternative premium sports property beyond cricket,” said Khanna. Live sports remain one of the few categories that consistently attract mass, real-

time viewership, per Pramod Pawar, Quantitative Research-Vice President, Hansa Research Group. This means that beyond awkward match timings, the real challenge for advertisers is the mode of viewing. “With the growing second-screen behaviour, advertisers today have more ways to connect with fans. Repeat telecasts and match highlights can provide Zee with an additional platform to monetise ad inventory and drive incremental advertising. The final impact on ad revenues will depend on how effectively Zee monetises this cross-platform engagement,” said Pawar.

YCH Group to invest ₹1,000 crore in India, eyes logistics parks in four major cities

T E Raja Simhan
Chennai



Josy Sebastian, Country GM, YCH Logistics (India) Pvt Ltd
BUJOY GHOSH

Singapore-based logistics major YCH Group plans to invest up to ₹1,000 crore in India over the next three to five years as it seeks to capitalise on rising demand for organised warehousing, automation and technology-driven supply chain solutions, particularly from the electronics, e-commerce and emerging semiconductor sectors. The company, which has been operating in India for the last 17 years, expects its India revenue to triple from the current ₹400 crore to ₹1,200-1,500 crore within three years. YCH currently operates through 60 locations across 40 cities in India and employs nearly 1,500 people, including contract workers.

proached the State Industries Promotion Corporation of Tamil Nadu for additional land to support the expansion. According to the company, the next phase of growth will be driven by large integrated ‘district parks’ spanning 30-40 acres, with built-up areas ranging from 5 lakh to 10 lakh sq/ft.

Following Chennai, similar projects are planned in Bengaluru and Mumbai/Bhiwandi, while Hyderabad and Bhubaneswar are also being evaluated. Electronics remains one of YCH’s strongest business verticals. The company currently works with more than 30 overseas electronics suppliers, storing inventory in special economic zones and supplying components on a just-in-time basis to manufacturers. Beyond inbound component logistics, the company handles finished goods distribution, reverse logistics and spare-parts management for sectors such as electronics, ATMs and telecom equipment. YCH also plans to enter India’s growing semiconductor logistics ecosystem

and is in discussions to acquire land in Gujarat for a project targeted for commissioning by 2027. **GROWTH DRIVER** The company sees automation as a key growth driver as customer expectations around quick commerce and rapid fulfilment continue to rise. It is investing in warehouse management systems, transport management systems and customised supply-chain software through its in-house technology arm. Technologies such as automated storage and retrieval systems, robotics, IoT-enabled warehousing and AI-driven logistics are expected to play a much larger role over the next five years as labour costs increase.

LOGISTICS PARKS The company’s first major expansion is planned near Sriperumbudur in the Chennai region, where it already operates its largest Indian facility — a 3.5 lakh sq ft warehouse spread across a 20-acre campus with storage capacity of around 45,000 pallet positions. The proposed Chennai logistics district park could attract investments of ₹400-500 crore. The company has ap-

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Sd/-, Managing Director

Enterprise Connect

SBI advances clean mobility and community empowerment through bicycle distribution drive



State Bank of India, has contributed ₹15.92 lakh under its Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives towards distribution of 200 bicycles through Sri Siddhivinayak Ganapati Mandir Trust for the benefit of underprivileged individuals across Mumbai. The initiative, undertaken by SBI's Mumbai Metro Circle, aims to encourage sustainable and environment-friendly modes of transportation while supporting the daily mobility needs of economically weaker sections of society. By promoting clean and accessible transport solutions, the initiative seeks to improve last-mile connectivity, support livelihoods, and enable easier access to education, work and essential services for beneficiaries. The CSR initiative was carried out in the distinguished presence of Hon'ble Chief Minister of Maharashtra Shri Devendra Fadnavis, Deputy Chief Minister Shri Eknath Shinde, Mayor of Mumbai Ms. Ritu Tawde, along with trustees of Sri Siddhivinayak Ganapati Mandir Trust. The donation cheque was formally handed over by Smt. Manju Sharma, Chief General Manager, Mumbai Metro Circle, and Shri Asit Ranjan, General Manager, Mumbai Metro Circle, underscoring SBI's continued focus on sustainable and socially impactful community initiatives.

MIT ADT University Students Create India's Largest Radio-Controlled Electric Airplane



In a landmark achievement for student-led aerospace innovation in India, students of MIT Art, Design and Technology University have successfully designed, developed, and flown India's largest radio-controlled (RC) electric fixed-wing airplane, "Project GARUDA," under "Team Skytrek." The airplane, developed entirely by students of the School of Engineering & Science – Department of Aerospace Engineering and funded by MIT ADT University's Centre for Research, Innovation & Entrepreneurship for Young Aspirants (CRIEYA), features a massive 9.25-metre wingspan and an all-up weight of 261 kilograms, making it the largest and heaviest radio-controlled electric airplane built in India. The university sanctioned a total funding amount of ₹48,00,000 (Forty-Eight Lakhs) for the project under CRIEYA. Following its successful flight, Project GARUDA has now been officially included in both the India Book of Records and the Asia Book of Records. The project was carried out under the visionary guidance of Dr. Mangesh Karad, along with Dr. Rajesh S., Provost Dr.Sayalee Gankar, Dr. Ramchandra Puji, Dr. Mohit Dubey, with continuous support from Dr. Sudarshan Sanap, Registrar Dr.Mahesh Chopde, Dr. Kamlesh Kulkarni, Dr. Sunil Dingare, and Dr. Santosh Darade. The airplane was entirely designed, fabricated, assembled, tested, and operated by students.

Business Initiative

State Institute of Administrative Careers (SIAC) provides comprehensive guidance - Preliminary Examination, Main Examination, and Personality Test



Organized as part of the institution's Golden Jubilee Year celebrations, tOrganized as part of the institution's Golden Jubilee Year celebrations, the program highlighted the remarkable achievement of 25 students from SIAC qualifying in the Civil Services Examination and 14 students succeeding in the Indian Forest Service Examination. Since last year, the Institute has also been actively encouraging and guiding students aspiring for the Indian Forest Service Examination, which has resulted in a significant number of successful candidates this year. SIAC provides comprehensive guidance at every stage of the examination process, including the Preliminary Examination, Main Examination, and Personality Test (Mock Interview). The Institute's Interview Guidance Programme for the Civil Services Examination has been particularly successful, with more than 22 candidates who attended the programme securing success in the final results this year. The successful placements were felicitated by Hon'ble Shri Chandrakant Dada Patil, Minister for Higher and Technical Education. In her introductory remarks, Dr. Bhavana Patole welcomed the dignitaries and participants. She expressed confidence that these students, who are now entering public service, will contribute significantly to nation-building by strengthening the country's administrative system in the years to come. The event was attended by Dr. Shailendra Deolankar, Director of Higher Education, Pune; Dr. Borade, Joint Director, Pune; Dr. Raut, Joint Director, Mumbai.

KEEL Laying ceremony of MPV (Yard-21003) built for M/s Navi Merchants



The Keel Laying Ceremony of the Third ship (Yard-21003) of the 7500DWT Multi-Purpose Hybrid Vessel (MPV) project for M/s Navi Merchants, Denmark, being built by Mazagon Dock Shipbuilders Ltd (MDL), a Navratna DPSU was held at MDL's South Yard on 20 May 2026. The prestigious Keel Laying function was graced by Mr. Rasmus Saltofte, CEO, M/s Navi Merchants with senior officials from M/s Navi Merchants, the Classification Society (DNV) and MDL. As per the contract signed between MDL and M/s Navi Merchants, MDL will design, build and deliver Six Multi-Purpose Vessels. The overall length of this Multi-Purpose Dry Cargo ship is 116.2m with a dead weight of 7500T. The vessel is with Hybrid Propulsion System and will be capable of attaining the speed of not less than 11.0 knots with shaft generator power take off of about 85 KW. The vessel will be built under survey and certification with rules of Det Norske Veritas (DNV) classification society. Today's Keel laying ceremony marks a significant milestone in the construction of the series of vessels being built under this export order by MDL.

A CH-CH₂

QUICKLY.

Maharashtra acquires Air India's Mumbai building

Mumbai: The Maharashtra government has completed the acquisition of the iconic 22-floor Air India building in Mumbai. The transfer agreement was signed between AI Assets Holding Ltd and the State's PWD Department on Tuesday in the presence of Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis. The State government had in 2023 decided to acquire the building for ₹1,600 crore to consolidates its offices in south Mumbai. **OUR BUREAU**

AHEAD opens third India office in Bengaluru

Bengaluru: AHEAD, the Chicago-based IT company, has opened an office in Bengaluru, its third in India after its flagship delivery centre in Gurugram and office in Hyderabad. With over 700 workers across its India Centre of Excellence, it provides consulting, transformation and support for AI, cloud, cybersec- urity, platform engineering and IT outsourcing. **OUR BUREAU**

Plan to close Srinagar airport in Oct worries tourism industry

Press Trust of India

Srinagar

The Srinagar International Airport will suspend all flight operations for 15 days from October 1 for runway maintenance, raising alarm bells within the tourism industry that fears the shutdown will deal a massive blow to the sector as it directly clashes with the peak Durga Puja holiday season.

According to airport officials, a phased maintenance schedule will begin ahead of the total shutdown and start-

With three ports nearing completion, Andhra Pradesh to get infra boost

SHIPPING HUB. State has five sea ports under construction, involving a total investment of ₹22,833 crore

G Naga Sridhar

Amaravati

Three of the five greenfield ports under construction in Andhra Pradesh are expected to be ready within the next six months, significantly boosting the State's maritime infrastructure and cargo-handling capabilities.

The ports at Machilipatnam, Ramayapatnam and Mulapeta are likely to be operational between December 2026 and March 2027. Once commissioned, they will raise Andhra Pradesh's total port cargo-handling capacity by more than 50 per cent.

“With the addition of these ports, the State's total cargo-handling capacity will increase from the current 195 million tonnes per annum to 286 mtpa,” MT Krishna Babu, Special Chief Secretary (Investments & Infrastructure), Government of Andhra Pradesh, told *businessline*.

The NDA government, led by Chief Minister N Chandrababu Naidu, has accorded high priority to the maritime sector, reviving stalled port projects and accelerating construction activity over the past two years as part of its broader strategy to strengthen the blue economy.

While Visakhapatnam port operates under the Government of India, the State's existing ecosystem includes Krishnapatnam port, developed under the public-private partnership (PPP) model, Kakinada anchorage port, Kakinada deep water port and Gangavaram port.

MEGA INVESTMENTS

The ports currently under development are Machilipatnam, Ramayapatnam, Kakinada SEZ port, Mulapeta (Bhavanapadu) and the captive AM/NS Rajayapeta port. The five upcoming ports together entail an investment of ₹22,833 crore.



ADDING MUSCLE. The three ports will raise Andhra Pradesh ports' cargo handling capacity by more than 50% to 286 mtpa

In addition, the State has formed a special purpose vehicle (SPV) to develop a mega shipbuilding cluster at Duggarajapatnam. The proposed cluster is envisaged to have a shipbuilding capacity of 1.2 million gross tonnage and is expected to attract investments of around ₹29,000 crore, positioning Andhra Pradesh as a major ship-

building hub on India's eastern coast.

Andhra Pradesh's maritime strategy seeks to integrate ports with industrial corridors, logistics parks, manufacturing clusters and multimodal connectivity to accelerate port-led industrialisation. The State is aligning port development with the Visakhapatnam-Chennai

Industrial Corridor (VCIC), coastal economic zones, skill development initiatives and employment generation in coastal communities, while promoting a sustainable blue economy, the official said.

The State aims to have at least one port ranked among the world's top 20 ports and account for 20 per cent of the total cargo handled by Indian ports by 2047.

OPTIMAL UTILISATION

As part of its roadmap, the State plans to maintain an optimal port capacity utilisation rate of 75 per cent by 2030 and reduce vessel turnaround time to less than 15 hours, enhancing operational efficiency and competitiveness.

The government is also targeting to train 5,000 maritime professionals by 2028 through a proposed maritime university and a network of skill development centres across the coastal districts.

Govt transfers CBSE Chairperson & Secretary, institutes inquiry

Meenakshi Verma Ambwani

New Delhi



The government on Tuesday transferred Rahul Singh, Chairman, Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), and Board Secretary Himanshu Gupta in the wake of widespread concerns over irregularities in digital evaluation system of the Class 12 Board Exam.

The government also set up a one-member committee to look into the procurement process adopted by the CBSE for services of its On-Screen Marking System.

In an official notification, the government named Lokhande Prashant Sitaram as the new Chairperson.

The development follows a week of students flagging discrepancies, such as mismatch of scanned answer sheets against their roll numbers, inaccurate scoring and missing pages in scanned answer books, among others. At the same time, cybersecurity researchers and ethical hackers revealed several critical vulnerabilities in the On Mark Portal. Allegations of discrepancies in the manner the OSM contract was awarded to Contempt Edu Teck also surfaced.

According to an official notification, the government has set up a one-member committee, chaired by S Radha Chauhan, Chairperson of the Capacity Building Commission, to “inquire into matters relating to procurement of services for On-Screen Marking System by CBSE”.

The committee has been asked to submit its report within a month to the Department of Personnel & Training.

The portal for verification and re-evaluation process was earlier slated to go live on May 29 but was postponed till June 1. Eventually, it got operationalised in the early morning hours of Tuesday.

In the afternoon, the CBSE said attempts were made to disrupt the portal's operations. “The CBSE re-evaluation portal is currently supporting over 8,000 concurrent users. As of 3 pm today (Tuesday), more than 16,000 students have successfully completed their submissions. While thousands of students accessed the CBSE re-evaluation portal today, malicious actors attempted to disrupt services through a barrage of cyberattacks. Most recent being a denial of service attack attempt causing 1.5 million hits on the portal within a matter of 2 minutes and more than 1 lakh attempts of unauthorised file access,” it said in a post on X.

RAHUL SLAMS GOVT

Reacting to the developments, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi in a post on X said, “This isn't accountability — it's a cover-up. Our demand remains the same today: Dismiss the Education Minister and conduct an independent judicial inquiry — these aren't some one-month-old internal file of the Modi government to be brushed aside just like that. If the Prime Minister cared about the 18.5 million CBSE students — Dharmendra Pradhan ji would have been removed long ago.”

Chennai needs a second airport, urges CII Southern Region's Ravichandran

Our Bureau

Chennai

Amid uncertainty over whether the Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) government in Tamil Nadu would proceed with the proposed greenfield airport at Parandur, the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII) has reiterated the need for a second airport for Chennai. We will respect whatever decision the State government ultimately takes, it added.

The South has some of the best airports in the country. “We have world class airports in Bengaluru and Hyderabad, and Tamil Nadu deserves to be in the top three and not just in the top seven,” P Ravichandran, Chairman, CII Southern Region and President of Danfoss India, said.

Addressing his maiden press conference after assuming office as Chairman of



P Ravichandran, Chairman, CII-SR **RAGU R**

the CII Southern Region, Ravichandran underscored the importance of strengthening Tamil Nadu's aviation infrastructure.

“We don't know what stand the government will take on Parandur greenfield airport project. Whatever they decide, we need to respect that decision. We did not discuss this issue when the CII delegation met Chief Minister C Joseph Vijay recently,” he added.

The Kashmir Valley traditionally witnesses a massive influx of tourists from West Bengal during October

influx of tourists from West Bengal during October.

This period is fondly called “Golden Kashmir”, as during the autumn season leaves of Chinar trees turn golden yellow.

Travel operators and industry leaders fear that the airport's closure will lead to widespread cancellations and heavy financial losses for an economy that is still recuperating from the impact of last year's Pahalgam terror attack, which resulted in an extended shutdown of tourism.

MAJOR CONCERNS

Industry leaders have expressed deep concern over the timing of the repairs and have appealed to the government and the Airports Authority of India to revisit the

scheduled closure.

Asif Burza, a prominent hotelier, said that while the upgradation of the airport was very important, the airport should not be fully closed.

“The repair works and upgrades are very important for the future. It is a matter of convenience for travellers, but at the same time, efforts should be made to lessen the inconvenience to the people,” Burza, who has properties across the famous tourist destination in the Valley, he said.

Kashmir Chamber of

Dairy Co-op, Assam Rifles ink supply pact

Our Bureau

New Delhi

The National Cooperative Dairy Federation (NCDFI) and Assam Rifles signed an agreement on Tuesday to expand the supply of milk and dairy products to military units across the North-East region. The deal is expected to generate additional revenue of about ₹44 crore per year for the cooperatives.

Cooperatives like Amul, Nandini and Warana are already supplying UHT milk and whole milk powder to units of Assam Rifles. However, the current MoU, signed in New Delhi, will enable more cooperatives to supply to more units.

Fresh milk and butter will now reach 72 military establishments across the seven North-Eastern States, while Amul will additionally supply cheese and malt-based food, NCDFI said in a statement.

Push for Cabinet berths intensifies ahead of DK Shivakumar's swearing-in today

Siddhi Patil

Bengaluru



DK Shivakumar

Even as preparations gather pace for DK Shivakumar's swearing-in as Karnataka Chief Minister on Wednesday, intense lobbying continues over Cabinet berths. Some 20-25 Ministers are expected to be inducted in the first phase, with the party high command likely to keep three to four positions open for future political adjustments and to manage potential dissensions.

Karnataka can have a 35-member Council of Ministers, including the Chief Minister, under the Constitution's 15 per cent cap on Cabinet size.

Political analyst Harish Ramaswamy said filling all 34 berths on day one is highly unlikely. Instead, the leadership will “always keep around 10 berths vacant” to enable “troubleshooting”

oral gains, the government is also expected to bring structural “changes in the face of ministries, giving some stress to Kittur Karnataka and Kalyana Karnataka regions, along with prioritising younger faces.

INCOMING GOVT

Speaking to *businessline*, a BJP spokesperson criticised Shivakumar, saying “he has always been more concerned about becoming Chief Minister than fulfilling his responsibilities. Therefore, we would not expect anything good from him.”

The swearing-in ceremony is scheduled at Lok Bhavan between 4 pm and 5 pm on Wednesday. Congress leader HC Balakrishna has confirmed the presence of all Chief Ministers from Congress-ruled States, along with senior national leaders.

The writer is an intern

Disney leases office space in Bengaluru

Our Bureau

Bengaluru

Entertainment major Disney India has leased nearly 1.75 lakh sq ft of office space at RMZ Ecoworld in Bengaluru's Bellandur.

According to property data analytics platform Propstack, Disney (India) Pvt Ltd has taken 1.74 lakh sq ft at RMZ Ecoworld Series 20.

The space has been leased from Vismaya Infrastructure Pvt Ltd. The lease, which is scheduled to commence on February 1, 2026, has been signed for a tenure of five years.

Disney will pay a monthly rental of about ₹2.01 crore, translating to a rental rate of ₹115 per sq ft per month. The agreement includes a security deposit of approximately ₹12.07 crore and a rental escalation clause of 15 per cent every three years.

ED conducts searches at Vedanta Group firms

Our Bureau

New Delhi

The Enforcement Directorate (ED) has initiated action into alleged foreign exchange violations by the Vedanta Group and carried out searches at multiple premises.

The searches were conducted at four locations linked to Vedanta Ltd, including its offices in Delhi, Mumbai and Udaipur, Rajasthan.

The agency, however, has not disclosed the specific nature of the alleged violations by the company.

REGULATORY PROCESS

Confirming the ED action, a Vedanta spokesperson said, “We are extending full co-operation to the authorities and are providing all inform-

ation sought. The company remains committed to compliance with all applicable laws and regulations. As the matter is currently under regulatory process, we are unable to comment further at this stage,” the spokesperson said.

According to officials, one of the transactions under scrutiny relates to a partial refund of brand fees by London-based Vedanta Resources, the parent company of Vedanta Ltd, to its Indian subsidiary in 2023, they said.

DEMERGER PLAN

The development comes shortly after Vedanta's board approved a demerger plan that will split the company into four separately listed entities — Vedanta Aluminium Metal, Talwandi Sabo Power, Malco Energy, and Vedanta Iron and Steel.

As hailstorms batter apple orchards, demand for crop insurance grows in Kashmir

Gulzar Bhat

Srinagar



RELIEF FOR FARMERS. In his Budget speech in February, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah had announced provisions for insuring crops such as apple, saffron and litchi

Amid recurring spells of hailstorms wreaking havoc across Kashmir's apple belt, demands for the introduction of a crop insurance scheme have grown louder among growers.

According to meteorologists, the Valley witnessed at least seven hailstorms over the past month, causing widespread damage to apple orchards. “The exact extent of losses is yet to be assessed, but the repeated hailstorms have caused significant damage to apple crops across Kashmir,” said Bashir Ahmad Basheer, Chairman of the All Kashmir Fruit Growers and Dealers Association.

He said that in the absence of crop insurance, cultivators remain highly vulnerable to weather-related shocks.

HIGH VALUE CROP

The apple industry is the backbone of Kashmir's horticulture economy, generating an estimated ₹10,000 to ₹12,000 crore annually and supporting nearly 3.5 million livelihoods directly and indirectly.

Zahid Ahmad, an apple grower from Shopian, said, “The hailstorm knocked off a significant amount of fruit and foliage. I estimate the damage to be around 45 per cent. We are waiting for the implementation of the crop

insurance scheme so that growers have some protection against such losses.”

In his Budget speech in February, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah had announced provisions for insuring crops such as apple, saffron and litchi.

LONG WAIT

On May 23, Agriculture Minister Javed Ahmad Dar told reporters that the government would roll out the Re-structured Weather Based Crop Insurance Scheme (RWBCIS) within two months, and that the bidding process would be initiated shortly. “Even if the scheme is introduced within two months, this season will remain uncovered,” Basheer said.

Andhra Pradesh floats bid for airport near Nellore

G Naga Sridhar

Hyderabad

The Andhra Pradesh Airport Development Corporation has invited bids for development of a greenfield airport in Nellore.

The proposed airport site is located 30 km from Nellore at Dagadarthi on the Chennai-Kolkata Corridor (NH16).

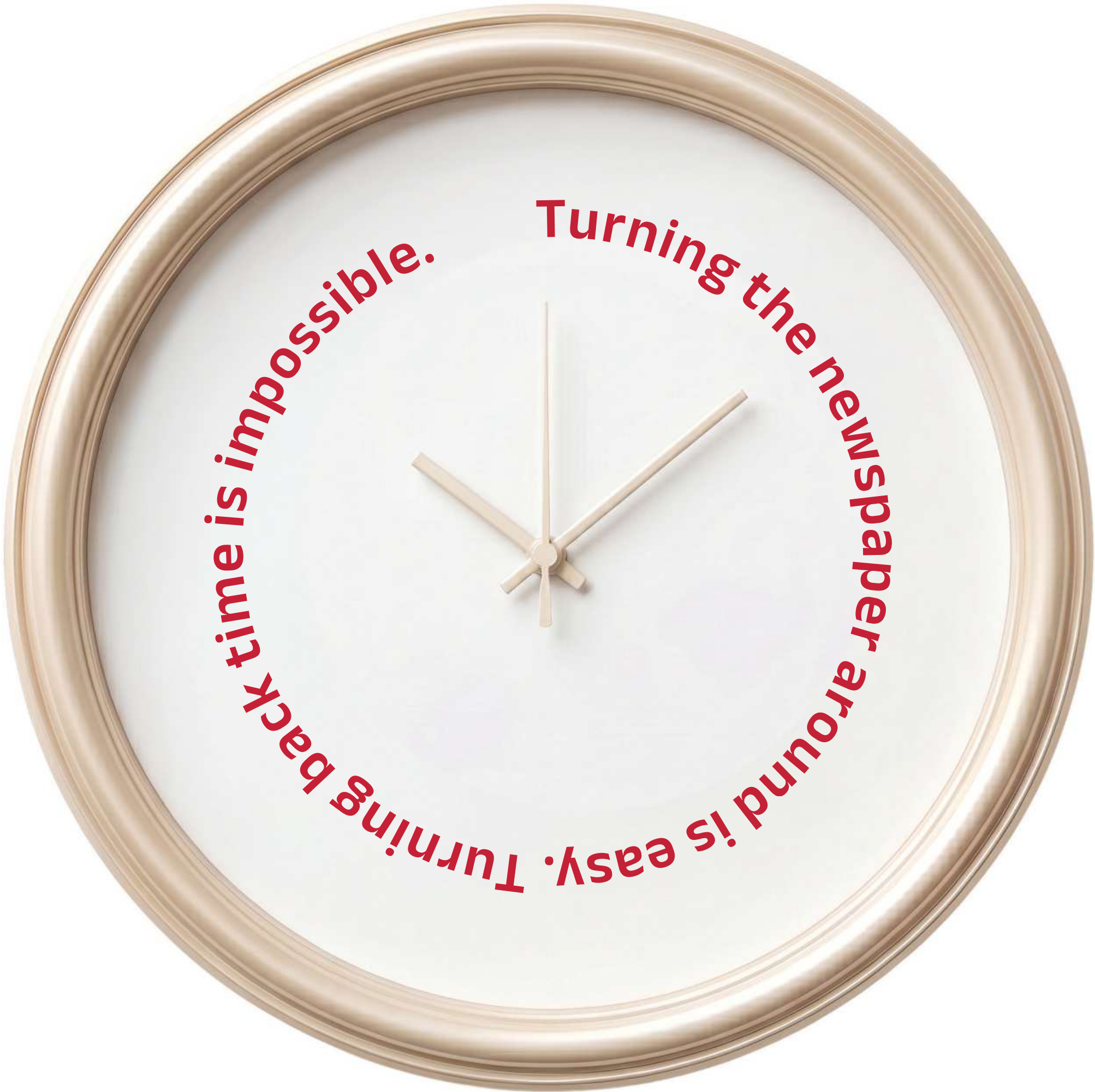
The location is connected to National Highway corridors, two major ports — Krishnapatnam and Ramayapatnam — and multiple industrial clusters, including KRIS City and IFFCO SEZs.

According to a notification by the corporation in association with the AP Economic Development Board (EDB), the last date for submission of bids is June 12,

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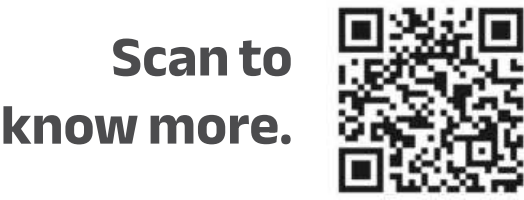


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